

₹6000

is now credited directly to my account

₹4.3 lakh crore disbursed under PM-KISAN, ₹26+ lakh crore worth of procurement at MSP, ₹2 lakh crore crop insurance, 8 crore Kisan Credit Cards - together these initiatives are strengthening the nation's Annadatas

12 Saal

Vishwas ke, Vikas ke, Jan-kalyan ke

CBC 011017/13/0005/2627

TRINAMOOL CRIES 'POLITICAL VENDETTA'

Mamata-Sonia meet; CID at home

Signature forgery case: CID raids TMC office at Mamata's residence, Abhishek's office

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI/KOLKATA: Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee on Tuesday met senior Congress leader Sonia Gandhi and discussed ways to further strengthen the Opposition INDIA alliance.

Sources said the two leaders are learnt to have discussed the strategy between the two parties going forward after the opposition bloc meeting, and following an exodus of Trinamool MPs after the party's defeat at the hands of the BJP in the recent West Bengal assembly polls.

Even as Mamata Banerjee, former West Bengal chief minister and Abhishek Banerjee, Lok Sabha MP, were in the national Capital for their scheduled meetings with opposition leader, the state CID launched



Congress MP Sonia Gandhi in a conversation with TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee during the INDIA bloc meeting, in New Delhi



TMC leader Kalyan Banerjee at party office during CID raid

simultaneous searches at Trinamool Congress's central office, Kalighat residence of TMC chief and at national general

secretary Abhishek Banerjee's Camac Street office in the city, probing alleged forged signatures of TMC MLAs that triggered a party split.

The agency officers said the raids were held to dredge out the original copy of TMC's

meeting resolution book and attendance sheet containing signatures of 70 MLAs present at the May 6 meeting held the

party office adjacent to Mamata Banerjee's residence. On Mamata-Sonia Gandhi meeting, Continued on P4

CLOSER LOOK

- » On Mamata-Sonia Gandhi meeting, both the parties did not disclose details but the sources said Banerjee is learnt to have stressed on Opposition unity, and asserted that the INDIA bloc should work together in taking on the BJP on various issues, including those concerning the public
- » The searches triggered a political storm, with several TMC leaders condemning the operation and alleging it was a politically motivated attempt to tarnish Mamata Banerjee's image
- » Rajya Sabha MP Derek O'Brien termed the CID operation a case of 'political vendetta shamelessly timed'
- » Abhishek wrote to the CID seeking additional time to appear before investigators in connection with the case

History made: Modi clears the Nehru line



MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A meeting of the ruling NDA combine to celebrate its government's completion of 12 years and Prime Minister Narendra Modi becoming the longest continuously serving elected PM of the country will be held here today.

All constituents of the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA) besides the top leadership of the BJP, including PM Modi, are expected to attend the meeting. Modi becomes the longest continuously serving elected prime minister of India, breaking the record of the first Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru.

A resolution hailing PM Modi for this feat is likely to be adopted at the meeting of the NDA partners, sources said. Modi will overtake the record of Nehru's 4,399 days in power as an elected prime minister following the 1952 general elections.

Former prime minister Indira Gandhi had a tenure of 14 years, more than that of Modi, but her prime minister-ship was not uninterrupted.

On May 26, 2014, Modi took charge as India's prime minister with a landslide victory. He got re-elected with a bigger mandate in 2019 and

MILESTONE

- » Modi becomes the longest continuously serving elected prime minister of India, breaking the record of the first Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru
- » Modi will overtake the record of Nehru's 4,399 days in power as an elected prime minister following the 1952 general elections

his second term began on May 30 of the same year. His third consecutive term started on June 9, 2024.

The NDA meeting, to be held at Bharat Mandapam, will be attended by chief ministers and deputy chief ministers of all 22 NDA governed states and Union Territories besides the leaders of all alliance constituents.

Senior Union ministers like Rajnath Singh, Amit Shah, J P Nadda and Shivraj Singh Chouhan among others are expected to attend the event, sources privy to the development said.

Union ministers belonging to the NDA constituents — K Ram Mohan Naidu (TDP), Rajiv Ranjan Singh (JDU), H D Kumaraswamy (JDS) and Anupriya Patel (Apna Dal-Soneylal) — Continued on P4

Trinamool flays rebels' 'double game'

Questions their numbers, morality and claims

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Mounting a scathing attack on the dissidents of Trinamool Congress, party MPs Kalyan Banerjee and Kirti Azad on Tuesday questioned their political morality, saying they are siding with the ruling BJP while retaining their identity as members of the party.

Addressing a press conference here, the two senior TMC MPs questioned whether the alleged resignation letter was actually there. "If you have a difference with the party, then you can resign from the party. But what letter do we know?"

KEY POINTS

- » 'If you have a difference with the party, then you can resign from the party. But what letter do we know?'
- » 'I wonder whether that letter is there because I have yet to see it anywhere. Why did that letter not get published if it was honest?'
- » 'Even if traitors get 19 MPs (2/3) which they have not — only option is to merge with BJP along with 2/3 of political party'

'Brutality': PoK boils, India blasts Pakistan

Urges global community to hold Pak accountable after deadly PoK violence

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India on Tuesday came down hard on Islamabad for its "brutality" against people in Pakistan-Occupied-Kashmir (PoK) and called on the international community to hold that country accountable for its "abuses".

India's reaction came as over 20 people were reportedly killed in police action on protesters in several parts of PoK.

External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal, slamming Pakistan, said there have been "desperate" attempts by Islamabad to cover up its "failings" and deflect attention away from its



alleged human rights abuses.

"We continue to see in this context, a pattern of fake news and

UN: India raps Pak over Afghanistan

UNITED NATIONS: In a scathing attack on Pakistan at the UN, India has condemned its "trade and transit terrorism" and deadly airstrikes against Afghanistan, saying that dressing up a massacre as a military operation does not absolve the perpetrator. "Pakistan's campaign of military airstrikes against Afghanistan is causing huge civil-

ian casualties and suffering to the Afghan people...Such unconscionable acts of violence are a blatant assault on Afghanistan's sovereignty and a threat to the region's peace and stability," India's Permanent Representative to the UN Harish Parvathaneni said at a meeting on the 'Situation in Afghanistan' in the UN Security Council Monday. See P6

videos emanating from Pakistan. It is a desperate attempt by Pakistan to cover-up its own failings

and deflect attention away from its human rights abuses," he said. Continued on P4

In a first, India deploys 12 nuclear warheads: SIPRI

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a significant shift in nuclear weapons policy, India has for the first time "deployed" 12 nuclear warheads, according to the latest report of the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI).

The world's top arms-tracking organisation, SIPRI, reveals a massive departure from decades of New Delhi's policy where nuclear warheads and delivery systems were kept in separate storage.

The report claims this is the first time India's arsenal has been classified as operationally deployed, rather than stockpiled.

Deploying ready-to-fire nuclear weapons in underground missile

silos and new nuclear submarines signals heightened readiness.

The 12 newly deployed warheads represent the first instance of India mating nuclear warheads with delivery systems or placing them at bases with operational forces, the report notes.

The SIPRI report further states that India's nuclear weapons stockpile saw a small spike in the last year, while deploying a small number of warheads on a ballistic missile submarine (SSBN) and conducting deterrence patrols.

India was estimated to have a growing stockpile of about 190 nuclear weapons as of January 2026—a small increase from the previous year. These weapons were assigned to a Continued on P4

OVER ALLEGED AFFIDAVIT OMISSION; ROW ERUPTS

Natarajan's RS papers rejected

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: Congress leader Meenakshi Natarajan's nomination for one of the three Rajya Sabha seats in Madhya Pradesh was rejected on Tuesday. Her papers were dismissed over allegations of concealing information related to a legal case in her affidavit.

The nomination of Congress candidate was rejected by the Returning Officer during scrutiny on Tuesday, dealing a major setback to the party's bid to secure one of the three seats up for polls.

The rejection followed objections raised by BJP nominee Mahesh Kewat, who alleged that Natarajan had not disclosed



Congress candidate Meenakshi Natarajan speaks to media after her nomination

proceedings related to a case in Telangana in her nomination papers. The decision was taken

IN MADHYA PRADESH

- » At a press conference later in the evening, Natarajan called it the BJP's attempt to manipulate the election
- » 'It all began when the ruling BJP fielded a third candidate despite lacking the requisite numerical strength'
- » The complaint was filed by senior BJP leader and Minister in the Mohan Yadav government, Kailash Vijayvargiya

after hearing both sides during the scrutiny process.

Continued on P4

FOLLOWING ODISHA'S REQUEST

CM: Bengal drops 'Dham' from Digha Jagannath Temple

CM assures implementation of Ghatal Master Plan

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: In a politically significant outreach that combined governance with symbolic course correction, Chief Minister Suvenud Adhikari on Tuesday announced that the word "Dham" would be dropped from the name of Digha's Jagannath Temple while simultaneously assuring the implementation of the long-pending Ghatal Master Plan after discussions with Ghatal MP Dev.



Suvenud Adhikari greets Sambit Patra

The announcements came amid an administrative review meeting in Kolaghat involving East Midnapore, West Mid-

napore and Jhargram districts, where the Chief Minister sought to project a model of governance that transcends party lines and encourages cooperation among elected representatives across the political spectrum.

Adhikari said the Digha shrine would henceforth be known as the 'Digha Jagannath Cultural Centre', in keeping with the original resolution of the erstwhile Trinamool Congress government.

Continued on P4

ATF prices jump 10%

NEW DELHI: Aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices were raised by around 10 per cent on Tuesday as state-owned fuel retailers rolled out a price stabilisation regime, offering domestic airlines a fixed fuel rate for up to three years in a move aimed at shielding carriers and passengers from sharp swings in global oil prices. Jet fuel for domestic airlines will now cost Rs 115 per litre, up from Rs 104.927, industry sources said. The new rate will be locked in for up to three years for airlines that opt to participate in the government-backed price stabilisation scheme. See P9

'Khan Sir' gets relief

Patna court stays arrest till further orders

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

PATNA: A Patna court on Tuesday stayed the arrest of educator Faisal Khan, popularly known as 'Khan Sir', till further orders, his lawyer said.

Khan was named in an FIR related to a firing incident by his guards a week ago when his coaching institute was allegedly vandalised by a bunch of miscreants. "The court has stayed his arrest till further orders, and ordered to present case diary and other antecedents on the next hearing," Khan Sir's lawyer Arvind Kumar Mouar told reporters here in Patna.

The educator had filed a plea for anticipatory bail on Monday. "All the facts have been put



Educator Faisal Khan, popularly known as 'Khan Sir'

before the court in accordance with law. After examining the case diary, the court is expected to pass the final order," the lawyer said.

He said that the next date has not been decided yet.

The court also asked for the case diary and antecedents in connection with the two guards who were detained by police on Thursday, Mouar said. Continued on P4

'Iran downed US helicopter'

DUBAI: US President Donald Trump said Tuesday that Iran was responsible for downing an American military helicopter near the Strait of Hormuz and that the US "must" respond to the attack.

Trump made the comment in a social media post after a drone boat rescued the crew of the Apache attack helicopter that crashed near the strategic waterway, which Iran has effectively closed during its war with the US and Israel. It was the first known drone rescue at sea by the US military, said Capt. Tim Hawkins, a spokesman for US Central Command. AGENCIES

MCD’s demolition drive gains pace as 16 demolished and 22 sealed

Issues show-cause notices to 21 constructions, 57 sealing show-cause notices

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi government authorities inspected 86 properties across the national capital on Tuesday, even as the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) demolished 16 properties and sealed 29 establishments, officials said.

The drive was part of an ongoing intensified crack-down on illegal constructions over safety violations following the recent Hauz Rani illegal Bed-and-Breakfast fire tragedy, where 22 people lost their lives.

According to the Revenue Department’s daily inspection report, 86 properties were inspected on Tuesday alone, while 538 properties were inspected between June 5 and June 9. It also involved issuing notices and carrying out sealing, demolition and eviction proceedings in coordination with civic authorities.

Also, the MCD on Tuesday issued 21 show-cause notices for unauthorised constructions, 57 sealing show-cause notices and 22 demolition



MCD officials carry out a demolition drive in Shalimar Bagh

PTI

orders, officials said.

Officials said that the enforcement drive has gathered pace after the Hauz Rani fire incident. They further said that between June 1 and June 9, the MCD demolished 139 properties and sealed 199 establishments across the city.

During the period, the MCD also issued show-cause notices to 132 unauthorised constructions, sealing show-

cause notices to 121 establishments and 64 demolition orders. The Revenue Department report showed action across several districts. In the South district, one property was sealed, and demolition action was initiated.

In the South-West district, demolition of excess structures and restraining orders against unauthorised developments were carried out.

In Short

» The enforcement drive comes in the wake of a series of tragedies in the city, owing mainly to lapses in civic infrastructure, flouting of fire safety norms, and corruption

» Officials said the civic body has carried out demolition action against 139 properties and sealed 199 more between June 1-9

while in the East district, property owners were asked to provide documents and approvals.

In the South-East district, joint surveys were conducted at unauthorised construction sites in Madanpur Khadar, while MCD initiated action against an under-construction property in Daryaganj.

In the North district, authorities issued restraining orders and notices in cases involving illegal construction and unauthorised borewells.

Meanwhile, MCD South Zone Deputy Commissioner Rakesh Kumar, during an inspection to review fire safety preparedness in south Delhi, said the exercise was aimed at identifying vulnerable establishments, particularly ground-floor eateries and other premises susceptible to fire hazards. “As a precautionary measure, we are inspecting vulnerable establishments, especially those on the ground floor and eateries where fire risks exist. The exercise will be carried out uniformly,” Kumar said.

The Old Delhi district saw one building sealed and punctured by the MCD and notices issued in another case.

In the North-East district, show-cause notices were issued to multiple hotels, guest houses, banquet halls and commercial establishments for violations of fire safety norms and building regulations. The Central and New Delhi districts also reported issuance of notices,

DU student held with hydroponic weed worth Rs 20 lakh

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 22-year-old Delhi University student was arrested for allegedly possessing and supplying hydroponic ganja, commonly known as OG, worth around Rs 20 lakh in the international market, police said on Monday.

The accused, identified as Jaseem Siyadul Farsan MP, a student of Satyawati College, was allegedly supplying drugs to college students and other clients to earn quick money and fund a lavish lifestyle, investigators said.

Police said the Anti-Narcotics Cell of the North-West district received a tip-off about a drug peddler selling hydroponic ganja near Vijay Nagar. Acting on the information, a police team conducted a raid under the supervision of Inspector Somil Sharma and ACP Operations Ranjeet Dhaka.

During the operation, the accused was intercepted and searched, leading to the recovery of 195 grams of hydroponic ganja, police said.

Hydroponic ganja, also known as OG, is a premium variety of cannabis cultivated



Was supplying drugs to college students and other clients to earn quick money

using advanced techniques and is sold at significantly higher prices in illegal markets.

A case under Section 20 of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act was registered at Model Town police station.

During interrogation, Jas-eem allegedly admitted to procuring and supplying hydroponic ganja to students of Satyawati College and other customers, police claimed.

Further investigation is underway to trace the source of the contraband and identify others linked to the supply network, officials added.

Constable found dead inside car

NEW DELHI: A Delhi Police constable posted in North-West Delhi was found dead inside his car near the Rohad toll plaza in Haryana, adding that the exact cause of death will be determined after the completion of medico-legal formalities and an investigation by the local police.

The deceased has been identified as Constable Sudhir, who was serving at the Adarsh Nagar Police Station in the North-West District of Delhi Police. His sudden demise has left colleagues and family members in shock.

According to the Delhi Police, information regarding the incident was received on June 8 at around 9:35 a.m. from Sudhir’s brother-in-law, Sehdev, who informed authorities that the constable had not returned home after completing his duty. Following the information, efforts were initiated to trace his whereabouts.

During the search, a Hyundai i20 car was found stationed near the toll plaza.

The vehicle drew attention after reports indicated that a person was inside and appeared unresponsive. Local police promptly reached the location and found Constable Sudhir inside the vehicle. **MP05T**

Nephew plots Rs 5.67L cyber fraud against uncle; held

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Cyber Cell of Delhi Police has arrested three persons, including the complainant’s nephew, for allegedly siphoning money from a businessman’s bank account through fraudulent UPI transactions, officials said.

The accused were identified as Nitin Gulati (43), a resident of Sri Nagar in Rani Bagh, Adil Salmani (27) of Raja Park, and Maninder Singh (30) of Sri Nagar, Rani Bagh.

Police said the case surfaced after Vinod Hira, a resident of Dilshad Garden who runs a boutique in Sarojini Nagar, lodged a complaint at Cyber Police Station Shahdara on May 14.

Hira alleged that more than Rs 5.67 lakh had been withdrawn from his State Bank of India account through unauthorised UPI transactions. The fraud came to light after a cheque of Rs 6,500 issued by him to the New Delhi Municipal Council bounced due to insufficient funds.

Following the complaint, police registered an e-FIR under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and launched an



investigation.

A special team comprising SI Sandeep Kumar, ASI Anil Kumar and HC Vikrant Sharma was formed under the supervision of SHO Cyber Vijay Kumar and overall guidance of the Deputy Commissioner of Police, Shahdara.

Investigators analysed bank transactions, UPI trails, IP logs and other digital evidence to trace the movement of the stolen money.

The probe revealed that the defrauded amount was routed through multiple bank accounts allegedly operated by Adil Salmani and Maninder Singh before reaching accounts linked to Nitin Gulati.

Acting on technical surveillance and intelligence inputs, police conducted raids across Delhi and arrested all three accused.

Hashim Baba gang shooter held in Farsh Bazar killings after hot pursuit

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Crime Branch has arrested a 34-year-old alleged member of the Hashim Baba gang wanted in connection with the sensational Farsh Bazar double murder case, officials said on Monday.

The accused, identified as Amir alias Saleem alias Tillan, a resident of Seelampur, was apprehended after a late-night chase on June 8 following specific intelligence inputs about his movement in the area.

Police said a Crime Branch team intercepted Amir, but he allegedly tried to flee and opened fire at the personnel. In retaliatory action taken in self-defence, a police officer fired at the accused, injuring him in the



leg. Despite the injury, Amir allegedly attempted to escape before being overpowered and arrested.

A .32 bore semi-automatic pistol made in Italy, four live cartridges and four empty cartridge cases were recovered from his possession, police said. A fresh case under relevant sections of the Bharatiya

Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act has been registered at the Crime Branch police station.

Amir was wanted in connection with the October 31, 2024 double murder in Farsh Bazar during Diwali celebrations. Akash Sharma and his nephew Rishabh Sharma were shot dead outside their residence, while Akash’s son Krish Sharma sustained bullet injuries. The incident, captured on CCTV and widely circulated on social media, had triggered panic in the locality.

Investigators had identified Amir and gangster Anil alias Sonu Matka as key accused in the case. Police said the murderers were linked to gang rivalry, personal enmity and financial disputes involving associates of the Hashim Baba gang.

Fire breaks out at GK 1, Kapashera; no casualties

NEW DELHI: A fire broke out at a multi-storey building in south Delhi’s Greater Kailash 1 area on Tuesday, prompting authorities to rush three fire tenders.

The Delhi Fire Services (DFS) said that it received a call regarding fire breaking out in an air conditioning unit on the upper floors of the building at 11.33 am. “We rushed three fire tenders to the spot. There is no information yet of anyone being trapped. Firefighting

operation is ongoing,” a DFS official said.

Meanwhile, another fire broke out at a slum cluster in southwest Delhi’s Kapashera area, prompting authorities to rush seven fire tenders to the spot, officials said.

No casualty was reported in the incident, they said.

According to the Delhi Fire Service (DFS), a call regarding the blaze was received at around 1.30 pm from Ambekar Colony in the area. **AGENCIES**

ENGAGES IN DRUNKEN FIGHT AT GARMENT FACTORY Man stabs co-worker to death with scissors

The accused, identified as Arwazwas nabbed from the Uttam Nagar area

On June 5, police received information regarding the admission of an injured man at Dr Hedgewar Hospital. The victim, identified as Krishan Kumar, had suffered stab injuries.

Police reached the hospital but found the injured unable to explain the circumstances of the attack or identify the assailant.

He later left the hospital without informing medical staff and declined to pursue legal action when contacted by police, officials said. The next day, police received information from GTB Hospital that Krishan Kumar had succumbed to injuries, prompting police to launch a probe into the matter. Investigators found that

the victim worked at a garment factory in Raghuwarpura-II, Gandhi Nagar. Following this, statements of the factory owner and workers were recorded.

Police said eyewitnesses revealed that a group of workers had been consuming liquor inside the factory on the night of June 4 when an argument broke out. During the altercation, Arwaz allegedly attacked another worker, identified as Tiger, and stabbed Krishan Kumar with a pair of scissors before fleeing the spot. **MP05T**

Police arrests Bawaria gang member on the run

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has arrested a proclaimed offender facing multiple cases with alleged links to the Bawaria gang, who was absconding for years, officials said on Tuesday. Jaiparkash alias Bittu (50), a native of Shamli district in Uttar Pradesh, was wanted in five cases, including for attempt to murder, robbery, snatching and under the Arms Act registered at different police stations in Delhi, police said. According to police, a tip-off about the movement of an active member of the Bawaria gang was received on June 5.

Using technical surveillance, including the Inter-operable Criminal Justice System (ICJS), the e-Prisons portal and local intel, a team from the Burari police station in north Delhi tracked and arrested Jaiparkash in the Sant Nagar market area the same day, police said.

During verification, the accused was found to be a proclaimed offender wanted in five criminal cases, including a 2013 snatching case, an attempt to

The accused was a proclaimed offender wanted in five criminal cases

murder case, a robbery and cheating case, and cases registered at Hauz Khas and Mehrauli police stations.

Various Delhi courts also issued non-bailable warrants against Jaiparkash, police said.

During interrogation, Jaiparkash disclosed that he was an active member of the Bawaria gang and had been living in rented accommodations in Mukundpur and nearby areas with other gang members.

The gang members frequently travelled to different states and allegedly targeted women wearing gold ornaments on trains. After committing the offence, they would change their addresses regularly to evade arrest, police said. **AGENCIES**

Fake Kala Jathedi gangsters nabbed over threat call

Hry businessmen pose as gang members to threaten trader

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has arrested two Haryana-based businessmen for allegedly impersonating members of the notorious Kala Jathedi gang and issuing extortion threats to a Delhi businessman, an official said on Tuesday.

The accused have been identified as Rajan Kalra (26), a resident of Yamunanagar, and Sahil Garg (38), from Haryana’s Jagadhari. Three mobile phones allegedly used in the commission of the crime have been recovered from them, police said.

The case came to light after Rohit Jain, a businessman engaged in the manufacture of plastic glue tapes in Bawana, approached Adarsh Nagar police station with a complaint that he had been receiving threatening calls from inter-

Takeaways

» The accused have been identified as Rajan Kalra (26), a resident of Yamunanagar, and Sahil Garg (38), from Haryana’s Jagadhari. Three mobile phones allegedly used in the commission of the crime have been recovered from them, police said

» During interrogation, both accused allegedly

national numbers.

Jain alleged that the callers claimed to be members of the Kala Jathedi gang and demanded money while threatening him with dire consequences, including death, if the demand was not met.



confessed to their involvement in the case and disclosed that they had no links with the Kala Jathedi gang

During the investigation, police found that Jain had an ongoing business dispute with Sahil Garg, who had earlier lodged a complaint against him alleging cheating and non-payment of around Rs 2.95 crore.

Police said the extortion-

ists allegedly claimed they had accepted a “token amount” of Rs 50 lakh from Garg to recover the disputed money and threatened to eliminate the complainant if he failed to pay.

An FIR was registered on June 7 under relevant provisions of the BNS relating to extortion and criminal intimidation.

Through technical surveillance and analysis of call records, investigators established that the accused were using both international and Indian phone numbers to issue threats.

The police team conducted raids at multiple locations in Karnal, Jagadhri and Yamunanagar in Haryana. Rajan Kalra was apprehended first, and subsequent questioning led to the arrest of co-accused Sahil Garg, police said. **AGENCIES**

City Briefs

GURUGRAM MAN LOSES JOB FOR ‘RS 370 BIRYANI’ REMARK AT STANDUP SHOW

GURUGRAM: A Gurugram firm has sacked one of its employees, who recently went viral for making a controversial “Rs 370 biryani” remark during stand-up comedian Pranit More’s show after widespread social media outrage over the incident. Gurugram-based web developer Himanshu Jangra faced a backlash for his comment, prompting Starvik Design, his employer, to fire him from his job, Vivek Vishwakarma, the founder of the firm, confirmed in a video posted on X. The controversy began after Jangra during the show recounted a date when he spent Rs 370 on a plate of chicken biryani. When the woman asked him to drop her home, he sought sexual favours for the money he spent on the biryani, Jangra said. More was seen laughing at Jangra’s comment. Later, both More and Jangra apologised for the incident.

FARIDABAD: JUNIOR ENGINEER, 2 LINE-MEN NABBED WHILE TAKING BRIBE

FARIDABAD: The Anti-Corruption Bureau here has arrested a junior engineer and two linemen of the electricity department while taking bribes, officials said on Monday. The accused allegedly demanded a bribe from a consumer, Dushyant Saini, in exchange for increasing the capacity of his electricity meter.

RELIEF FOR 15 LAKH RESIDENTS

No demolition of existing homes in O-Zone Colonies, CM assures

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Bringing relief to nearly 15 lakh residents living in Delhi's O-Zone areas, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday clarified that no demolition action will be taken against existing constructions in the 91 unauthorised colonies and several old villages located in the Yamuna floodplain zone. The assurance came after a high-level meeting at the Delhi Secretariat amid growing anxiety among residents following recent court proceedings and notices installed in the area.

The meeting was attended by North East Delhi MP Manoj Tiwari, South Delhi MP Ramvir Singh Bidhuri, Trans Yamuna Area Development Board Chairman and MLA Arvinder Singh Lovely, Chief Secretary Rajeev Verma, MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khairwar, and senior officials of the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) and other departments.

During the meeting, officials informed the Chief Minister that around 91 colonies and nearly a dozen old villages fall within the O-Zone and are



TAKEAWAYS

» During the meeting, officials informed the Chief Minister that around 91 colonies and nearly a dozen old villages fall within the O-Zone and are home to approximately 15L people

» Residents have been worried due to signboards installed by authorities, but public

representatives told the meeting that after examining High Court orders and government records, they found that existing structures were not under threat

» The court's directions, relate only to new or ongoing construction

» Public representatives also raised concerns over the wording of the notice boards

home to approximately 15 lakh people. Residents have been worried due to signboards installed by authorities, but public representatives told the meeting that after examining High Court orders and government records, they found that existing structures were not under threat. The court's directions, they said, relate only to new or ongoing construction activities.

Public representatives also raised concerns over the wording of the notice boards installed in O-Zone colonies,

saying they were creating confusion and panic among residents. They alleged that some elements were exploiting the situation by spreading fear while simultaneously carrying out illegal construction activities. Representatives further demanded strict measures to protect the Yamuna floodplain and said they had no objection to a complete ban on fresh construction in the O-Zone.

Seeking clarification from DDA officials, the Chief Minister observed that the court had not made any remarks regard-

ing completed constructions. "The Hon'ble High Court had not made any observations regarding constructions that had already been completed, but had raised concerns about ongoing construction activities," she said. Gupta added that since the court had already communicated its position to the DDA, the authority should act accordingly.

Reaffirming the government's commitment to residents, the Chief Minister said she would soon meet Union Housing and Urban Affairs

Minister Manohar Lal along with public representatives to discuss a permanent resolution. She also directed DDA officials to revise the wording of the notice boards in line with the court's observations so that residents do not face unnecessary panic. Addressing a subsequent press conference, MP Ramvir Singh Bidhuri said, "Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has also made it clear that no demolition of any kind will be carried out in the old inhabited areas falling under the O-Zone." He added that BJP MPs would soon meet Union Minister Manohar Lal Khattar to present the factual position and seek justice for the 15 lakh affected residents.

MP Manoj Tiwari said, "We have already initiated the entire process to rectify the erroneous inclusion of certain areas in the O-Zone." He accused previous governments of failing to resolve the issue and asserted that existing houses would not be harmed. "Only new constructions would be subject to compliance with the court's directions," he said, urging residents not to fall prey to misinformation or fear.

Delhi government employees to get incentive for using public transport

Scheme will be implemented for a period of six months

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: To encourage greater use of Delhi Metro and DTC buses, the Delhi government is offering an incentive to its employees on travel allowance if they use the common mobility card, officials said on Tuesday.

The initiative comes as part of the Delhi government's efforts to promote public transport amid concerns over fuel conservation linked to the West Asia crisis.

"In view of considering the need for prudent utilisation of fuel resources arising due to the ongoing situation and further, in continuation of the government's efforts towards conservation of fuel, reduction in pollution and promotion of public transport, it has been decided to introduce an incentive scheme for the employees of GNCTD (Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi) utilising metro and public transport services for commuting purposes," an order said.

According to the order of the finance department, if an employee utilises at least 25 per cent of their monthly transport allowance, excluding Dearness Allowance, towards the purchase or recharge of a common



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta last month launched the 90-day 'Mera Bharat, Mera Yogdan' fuel-saving campaign

mobility card, they shall be eligible for an incentive of 10 per cent of the admissible transport allowance, which will be provided with the salary.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta last month launched the 90-day 'Mera Bharat, Mera Yogdan' fuel-saving campaign, stipulating two-day work-from-home for all Delhi government employees and the use of public transport.

Last month, the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) also announced that it will run special buses for Delhi govern-

ment employees from their residences to the nearest metro station and then to the Delhi Secretariat.

"All officers and officials, with their consent, will be provided a common mobility card issued by DTC in a manner as prescribed by the finance department in consultation with DTC," the order added.

Initially, the incentive scheme will be implemented for a period of six months, with further extension to be done after assessment, it added.

DDA completes 70% desilting, Jun 15 deadline set for remaining work

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: With the monsoon season approaching, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has completed around 70 per cent of its desilting work on stormwater drains across key parts of the Capital, officials said.

The large-scale exercise is being carried out under the direct monitoring of Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, who has been reviewing monsoon preparedness measures across civic agencies. The Lieutenant

Governor has directed officials to complete the remaining work by June 15, ahead of the expected onset of the monsoon.

According to the DDA, desilting operations are underway on nearly 261 km of stormwater drains under its jurisdiction, including 69 km in Narela and 192 km in Dwarka. The exercise involves the removal of accumulated silt, debris, vegetation and other obstructions that can impede the flow of rainwater and lead to waterlogging.

Officials said the drive was

launched well in advance following directions from the Lieutenant Governor to ensure smooth drainage during heavy rainfall, reduce urban flooding, ease traffic congestion and maintain public hygiene. Regular inspections are being conducted to monitor progress and maintain quality standards.

The L-G had directed the DDA to undertake the desilting drive in mission mode to tackle recurring waterlogging. Officials said timely completion would improve drainage efficiency and reduce water accumulation during the monsoon.

CM attack case: Court denies bail to accused

NEW DELHI: A court here has denied bail to a man accused in a case related to the assault of Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at a public meeting, saying the allegations against him were grave and supported by material collected during investigation.

Additional Sessions Judge Nishant Garg was hearing a bail plea filed by Tehsin Raza, who was accused of conspiring with co-accused Sakriya Rajeshbhai Khimjibhai to kill the chief minister.

In an order dated June 6, the court said, "Considering the nature and gravity of the offence, the possibility of the

accused fleeing from justice cannot be ruled out.

Accordingly, I do not consider it to be fit case for grant of bail. The bail application is accordingly dismissed."

According to the prosecution, the incident occurred on August 20, 2025, when the chief minister was conducting a 'Jan Sunvai' programme. The main accused allegedly attacked her, pulled her hair, threw her to the ground and attempted to strangle her before being apprehended on the spot, the prosecution said.

The court noted that during investigation, the main accused disclosed Raza's

alleged involvement in the conspiracy and claimed that he had shared with him videos taken during a recce of the chief minister's residence.

The prosecution further alleged that call detail records showed the two accused were in touch with each other and that Raza had transferred Rs 2,000 to the co-accused.

It was also alleged that the main accused had procured a knife for carrying out the offence and had shown it to Raza through a video call a day before the incident.

"The complainant and other eye witnesses are yet to be examined; the trial is pro-

ceeding without any undue delay; the accused/applicant Tehsin Raza is not a resident of Delhi and has no fixed place of occupation," the court said.

Rejecting the defence argument that there was no evidence of prior meeting of minds between the accused persons, the court said the material on record prima facie indicated their alleged conspiracy.

The court dismissed the bail plea, observing it was not a fit case for relief. In December, it framed attempt-to-murder charges against both accused, citing a prima facie case. P11

Malviya Nagar mattresses shop owner rewarded Rs 50K by AAP MP Sanjay Singh



OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: AAP Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh on Monday rewarded a local shopkeeper whose quick action helped save lives during the Malviya Nagar fire tragedy.

Singh visited the area and met those locals who were among the first responders to the major fire tragedy last week, which claimed the lives of 22 people and left several others injured.

"At a time when people were screaming for help and desperately trying to save themselves, some brave residents of this area displayed extraordinary courage, determination and bravery to save lives. I salute their courage," Singh said.

A local, Riyazuddin, who owns a mattress shop, put aside all concerns about his livelihood and personal losses and gave away all his mattresses to help save lives, he added.

"As a gesture of support, I am providing him with financial assistance of Rs 50,000 from my salary," Singh further said. He added that around 15 to 16 people survived by jumping onto those mattresses. The humanity and compassion shown by the people of this area is the true religion.

Vigilant citizens, visionary legislatures key to 'Viksit Bharat 2047': Speaker Vijender Gupta

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A developed India by 2047 will depend as much on aware and responsible citizens as on forward-looking legislatures, Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta said on Tuesday while addressing the Commonwealth Parliamentary Association (CPA) India Region Zone-II (North Zone) Conference in Haryana.

Speaking at the Plenary Session-II on the theme "Role of Aware Society and Legislators in Realising Future Challenges and the Goal of Viksit Bharat 2047", Gupta stressed that democratic participation and institutional vision must go hand in hand to achieve the country's long-term development goals.

"If citizens provide democratic vigilance, legislators must provide democratic direction; if society generates aspirations, institutions must convert those aspirations into outcomes," Gupta said. He further



observed that a truly developed nation cannot be measured solely by economic prosperity. "A truly developed India cannot be measured by wealth alone, but by the strength of its institutions, the awareness of its citizens, and a deeply shared culture of national responsibility," he said.

Addressing legislators and presiding officers from northern states, Gupta noted that India is undertaking its journey towards Viksit Bharat 2047 with confidence, supported by rapid economic growth and

major achievements in digital public infrastructure, renewable energy, space technology and public service delivery. He also highlighted India's success in preserving democratic institutions amid significant social, economic and technological transformations.

The Delhi Assembly Speaker cautioned that legislatures must prepare for emerging challenges over the next two decades. These include the rapid advancement of Artificial Intelligence and other disruptive technologies, climate change-related threats to agriculture and water resources, cybersecurity risks, urban infrastructure pressures and the need to equip India's youth for a knowledge-based economy.

Calling an aware society the first pillar of progress, Gupta said democracy thrives not merely through elections but through informed citizens who combat misinformation,

promote social harmony and remain conscious of their constitutional rights and duties.

On the role of legislatures, he argued that governance institutions must evolve to meet future challenges. "Law-making bodies cannot solve future challenges using the tools of the past," he said.

Referring to initiatives such as the National e-Vidhan Application (NeVA), Gupta highlighted how technology can make legislative institutions more transparent, citizen-centric and efficient. However, he cautioned that technology should complement rather than replace democratic values. "Digital tools and data must assist governance, but they can never replace wisdom, human accountability, and the core deliberative spirit of parliamentary democracy," he said.

Gupta stressed public participation in Viksit Bharat 2047 and presented 'Shatabdi Yatra' to Haryana Governor.

NDMC reviews Khan Market redev, seeks faster execution

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) reviewed the progress of an ongoing redevelopment project at Khan Market, with Vice-Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal inspecting the site and directing officials to expedite works while ensuring minimum inconvenience to visitors and traders.

The project, estimated at ₹1.21 crore, involves the redevelopment of the market's middle lane through the installation of an integrated drainage system and the upgradation of pavements and flooring. According to NDMC officials, the existing interlocking pavers had deteriorated over time and required frequent repairs due to heavy pedestrian movement and commercial activity.

The redevelopment plan includes new drainage lines, sewer and water supply infrastructure, electrical utility



ducts, granite stone flooring, interlocking pavers and stainless-steel dustbins. Officials said substantial progress had already been achieved, including the laying of drainage pipelines, construction of silt chambers and installation of utility connection chambers.

Chahal noted that the presence of a dense network of underground electrical cables and utility services beneath the six-metre-wide lane posed a challenge to the project's execution. He said NDMC was coordinating with relevant departments to explore solu-

tions such as temporary overhead power arrangements and relocation of feeder pillars to accelerate the work.

During the inspection, Chahal also visited Lok Nayak Bhawan and directed departments to undertake repair and maintenance works. He later inspected the Enforcement Department store at Safdarjung Airport, where a recent fire incident was reported, and instructed officials to strengthen safety measures and dispose of stored materials through timely auction processes.

Dusty winds hit city; IMD issues red, orange alerts

NEW DELHI: Strong dusty winds swept across parts of Delhi on Tuesday evening, bringing relief from the prevailing heat as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued red and orange alerts for thunderstorms, lightning, hail and rainfall.

According to the IMD's district-level nowcast, moderate rain accompanied by thunderstorms, lightning, hail and wind speeds of 60-80 kmph, gusting up to 90 kmph, was likely in several areas. Other parts of the city were expected to receive light to moderate rain with thunderstorms. Overcast skies and dust-laden winds were reported across Delhi. P11

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi's public buses are set to face stricter scrutiny, with Transport Minister Dr. Pankaj Kumar Singh warning officials that any lapse in passenger service, route operations or commuter safety will invite action. In a review meeting with senior Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) officials on Tuesday, the minister directed strict compliance with service standards and announced surprise inspections to ensure buses operate according to schedule and cater to passengers without discrimination.

Chairing a meeting with DTC Regional Managers, Singh reviewed day-to-day bus operations and emphasized that pub-



lic transport remains central to Delhi's mobility network.

"Public transport is the backbone of Delhi's mobility system. Every passenger deserves a safe, respectful and reliable journey. Any negligence towards passengers, especially women, senior citizens or Divyangjan, or any deviation from operational norms, will be dealt with strictly. Our focus is to ensure efficient, disciplined and pas-

senger-friendly bus services across Delhi," the minister said.

During the meeting, Singh directed that all DTC buses must halt at designated bus stops and ensure smooth boarding and disembarking of passengers. He stressed that no commuter should be denied a ride under any circumstances and instructed officials to pay special attention to women, senior citizens and Divyangjan passengers.

'THERE WAS SOME INFLAMMABLE MATERIAL IN HOUSE'

Jaipur: Eight people burnt alive in fire at cracker godown

OUR CORRESPONDENT

JAIPUR: Eight persons were burnt alive in a fire that raged after a blast at an illegal cracker godown here in Khoh Nagorian area on Tuesday morning, officials said.

The fire erupted in a small house in Ayesha Nagar Talai colony, where firecrackers were allegedly kept, they said.

Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma and Congress leader Ashok Gehlot offered their condolences over the incident.

Assistant Commissioner of Police Vinod Sharma said eight persons have died in the blaze.

Of them, five died during treatment at SMS Hospital while one, whose identity was yet to be ascertained, was brought dead. Two succumbed to critical burn injuries at a pri-



Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) officials inspect a site after fire broke out, at Kho-Nagorian area, in Jaipur, Rajasthan, Tuesday

PTI

vate hospital. Seven of the eight deceased were identified as Sameer, Aajim, Nasir, Abdul Wahid, Rabil, Bilal and Ashraf.

Jaipur Collector Sandesh Nayak said that according to

Highlights

» Police Commissioner Sachin Mittal said the house was being used as a godown for firecrackers, with a manufacturing unit in its vicinity

» Locals rescued some of the trapped and tried to douse the flames before the fire brigade arrived

preliminary information, combustible material stored inside the premises likely caused the fire.

"There was some inflammable material in the house, while the exact cause will be

established after a detailed investigation," Nayak said.

Police Commissioner Sachin Mittal said the house was being used as a godown for firecrackers, with a manufacturing unit in its vicinity.

"Prima facie, it appears to be a storage facility," Mittal said. Eyewitnesses said as flames rapidly engulfed the house, workers ran for their lives, some getting trapped inside.

A few of those who escaped collapsed on the road outside, while many lay writhing in pain.

Locals rescued some of the trapped and tried to douse the flames before the fire brigade arrived.

Kishanpole MLA Amin Kagzi went to SMS Hospital to enquire about the injured and pulled up authorities for allow-

ing a hazardous facility to operate in a residential area.

"Did the police not know that a gunpowder and fireworks factory was functioning in a residential locality? People are not speaking openly. There are still no clear answers about ownership and accountability," Kagzi told reporters.

He alleged collusion between authorities and those operating the facility, and accused the administration of putting other residents' lives in danger.

A local said that an explosion was heard before flames leapt up and swept the entire house.

"A water tanker was called, and we tried to enter with a hose pipe. We managed to pull out three or four people," he said.

Mamata in Delhi, CID at home...

Continued from Page 1

Both the parties did not disclose details but the sources said Banerjee is learnt to have stressed on Opposition unity, and asserted that the INDIA bloc should work together in taking on the BJP on various issues, including those concerning the public. At the INDIA bloc meeting here on Monday, Banerjee had urged all the constituents to forget the past and stand united.

Tuesday's meeting came after

Banerjee and Gandhi, the chairperson of the Congress Parliamentary Party, met each other warmly with a hug during the opposition meeting held at the Constitution Club near Parliament House.

The Congress shared pictures of the bonhomie between the two leaders.

The meeting also followed a rebellion within the Trinamool, with several party MPs deciding to form a separate group and align with the ruling NDA.

The CID searches in Kolkata triggered a political storm, with several TMC leaders condemning the operation and alleging it was a politically motivated attempt to tarnish Mamata Banerjee's image.

Senior leader Kunal Ghosh questioned the timing of the search, noting that CID officials arrived at Mamata Banerjee's residence while she was in Delhi attending INDIA bloc meetings with Sonia Gandhi. TMC Rajya Sabha MP Derek

O'Brien termed the CID operation a case of "political vendetta shamelessly timed".

Shortly after the CID team left, Rajya Sabha MP Sagarika Ghose posted on X that the search amounted to "humiliation, intimidation and vendetta". Sharing a photograph of a seizure list showing "NIL", she wrote that nothing had been seized, damaged or destroyed during the operation and questioned its purpose. She alleged that the search was aimed at

publicity and harassment of the former Chief Minister.

Dramatic scenes unfolded outside Mamata Banerjee's residence when CID officials attempted to enter the premises. Former Rajya Sabha MP Subhashish Chakraborty, who was in charge of the party office, initially refused to allow the team entry, leading to a brief exchange before officials entered the premises.

Soon after, MP Kalyan Banerjee arrived and sought

entry, claiming he was representing Mamata Banerjee as her lawyer. While CID officials searched for the meeting resolution book, Banerjee accused the BJP-backed state administration of trying to defame the TMC chief.

Banerjee further claimed that Chief Minister Suvedu Adhikari was pursuing a politics of revenge and using investigative agencies to harass Opposition leaders. He also maintained that no FIR had been registered

against Mamata Banerjee in the matter.

Meanwhile, as searches were underway at Abhishek Banerjee's Camac Street office, he wrote to the CID seeking additional time to appear before investigators in connection with the case.

The CID had summoned him on Monday, directing him to appear by 5 pm on Tuesday. After several hours of searching, CID officials left the Camac Street office in the evening.

Agency officials, accom-

panied by personnel from the Kalighat police station and a large contingent of women police personnel, arrived at the party's central office at 30B Harish Chatterjee Street in Kalighat at around 3 pm, sources said.

While the search operations at the Harish Chatterjee Street premises lasted for about two hours, the one at Camac Street went on for three, with no significant seizures made by the agency from either of the two premises, an officer said.

From Page 1 History made

are also likely to attend the meeting.

The leaders of NDA, and the central and state governments will exchange perspectives and best practices relating to boosting 'Ease of Living', 'Ease of Doing Business' and how to bring further reforms to realise the shared dream of a 'Viksit Bharat' by 2047, the sources said.

The meeting will focus on reviewing various national development programmes, infrastructure programmes and the Modi government's vision to transform the nation into a developed country by 2047.

The meeting is likely to deliberate on how to bring smooth synergy between the states and the Centre on the ongoing developmental schemes.

The prime minister had earlier outlined his government's reform priorities for the next decade, asserting that his government's "Reform Express" has delivered systemic transformation and benefited common citizens in a significant way.

At a recent meeting of the council of ministers of the Modi government, the prime minister had said that the Union ministers should work towards ensuring "ease of living" for the people.

He also told them that there should not be any interference in the people's lives in any way. The prime minister told the Union ministers to take all possible steps so that the people get maximum benefits from the government welfare programmes, the sources said.

Modi noted the focus in 2026 must be on future goals and achievements. He told the Union ministers this is the time to look forward, not dwell on what has been done in the past.

The prime minister advised the ministers to remain focused on governance and delivery, and stressed that there should be no pendency in government work, the sources said.

During the past 12 years, nearly 250 million Indians moved out of multidimensional poverty, rapid expansion of digital public infrastructure, large-scale infrastructure development, improvements in welfare delivery, and broad-based socio-economic progress.

During this period, India has strengthened its position as the world's fastest-growing major economy, concluded major trade agreements with leading economies, and emerged as a more influential voice on global issues, including development, technol-

ogy, climate action and the priorities of the Global South.

'Brutality'

"There are reports of severe police brutality in Pakistan Occupied Kashmir in which several protestors have been killed and many injured. We hope the international community will hold Pakistan accountable for its misdeeds and abuses," Jaiswal added.

He was responding to a question at a media briefing.

India's reaction came a day after Pakistan's human rights body said that it is "deeply alarmed" by the ongoing violence in PoK during violent clashes.

The Human Rights Commission of Pakistan (HRCP) also expressed serious concerns about the so-called regional government's decision to proscribe the Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC) under anti-terrorism legislation.

The JAAC has long been demanding the abolition of 12 "refugee seats" in the so-called Legislative Assembly in PoK.

The seats are reserved for refugees from Kashmir who settled in Pakistan after 1947. JAAC alleges that these seats were often used by mainstream Pakistani political parties to influence the formation of governments in Muzaffarabad.

India has lodged a strong protest with Pakistan over the recent elections, maintaining that PoK has been "illegally and forcibly" occupied by Pakistan.

SIPRI

maturing nuclear triad of aircraft, land-based missiles and SSBNs," the SIPRI report released on Monday says.

"It has long been assumed that India stores its nuclear warheads separate from its deployed launchers during peacetime. However, the country's recent moves towards placing missiles in canisters and conducting sea-based deterrence patrols suggest that India could be shifting in the direction of mating some of its warheads with their launchers in peacetime," the report says.

India follows the "no first use" policy when it comes to nuclear weapons. India commits to not being the first to initiate a nuclear strike. Nuclear weapons will only be used in retaliation against a nuclear attack on Indian territory or on Indian forces anywhere. India maintains a limited but effective nuclear arsenal. The capability is designed purely to deter potential aggressors rather than engage in an arms race.

Bengal drops

He maintained that the addition of the word "Dham" by the previous administration was inconsistent with Sanatan Dharma traditions and would now be withdrawn through a cabinet decision.

"The premises will now be called 'Sri Sri Jagannath Cultural Centre' and the deities of Lord Jagannath, Lord Balabhadra and Goddess Subhadra, at the temple within the premises, will be worshipped in accordance with prescribed norms and rituals," Adhikari said.

The move followed a meeting between Adhikari and Puri MP Sambit Patra, who handed over a letter from Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi urging the Bengal government to preserve the sanctity of Puri Jagannath Dham by removing the word "Dham" from the Digha temple's name.

"In keeping with tradition and sentiment, the word will be removed immediately. I have already informed Sambit Patra about the decision," Adhikari said.

In his letter, Majhi stated that the naming of the shrine as "Digha Jagannath Dham" had generated concern among devotees, religious scholars and socio-cultural organisations in Odisha and elsewhere.

Patra, speaking in the presence of the Chief Minister at Nabanna, said the term "Jagannath Dham" is intrinsically associated with the abode of Mahaprabhu Shree Jagannath at Puri, one of the four sacred Char Dham of India, and carries immense spiritual, historical and cultural significance.

Radharamn Das, Trustee and Chief Priest of the Digha Jagannath temple, welcomed the decision. "We wholeheartedly welcome the decision of the Hon'ble Chief Minister Shri Suwendu Adhikari Ji. The Hon'ble Chief Minister personally spoke with me regarding this matter, and we are very happy that the temple will now be known as Digha Jagannath Mandir," he said.

The Chief Minister also used the occasion to reiterate his government's commitment to providing a permanent solution to recurrent flooding in Ghatat and adjoining areas through the implementation of the Ghatat Master Plan.

Adhikari said the state administration had already initiated steps to carry forward the long-pending project and revealed that he had held detailed discussions with Ghatat MP Dev on the issue.

Welcoming the assurance, Dev said: "I have always believed in the politics of courtesy. Political differences may exist, but insulting anyone personally has never been my nature. The Chief Minister has personally assured me that the Ghatat Master Plan will be implemented."

Seeking to underline a new political and administrative cul-

ture, Adhikari said governance should not be held hostage to electoral rivalries.

"Politics will take place during elections, and it should end there. For the remaining days of the year, we must work for the people. We want to build that spirit of cooperation and bonding among public representatives. For us, an MLA is an MLA; party affiliation does not matter," he said.

The Kolaghat meeting brought ruling and Opposition representatives onto the same platform. According to the Chief Minister, all 35 legislators invited to the meeting attended the session, including two opposition MLAs, while all four Members of Parliament from the Medinipur region also took part.

Adhikari claimed the participatory format of the meeting had drawn appreciation from opposition representatives. According to him, one opposition MP remarked that they were "overwhelmed" by the freedom given to participants to openly express their views during the discussions.

'Khan Sir'

"Their case is scheduled for tomorrow. The hearing will take place after the case diary is presented before the court," the lawyer said.

The educator has received "protection from coercive action" and will cooperate with investigating officers for whatever queries they may have.

A group of 15-20 persons allegedly vandalised Khan Global Studies Institute in the state capital Patna on June 2 night and pelted stones at its premises.

Police had on Thursday detained two guards associated with Khan Sir's coaching institute for allegedly firing shots on June 2 night.

Natarajan's

At a press conference later in the evening, Natarajan called it the BJP's attempt to manipulate the election.

"It all began when the ruling BJP fielded a third candidate despite lacking the requisite numerical strength. It became evident that they were engaging in politics designed to trample upon the Constitution and democracy," she said.

Natarajan's nomination was rejected during scrutiny and the Congress cannot field another candidate now since the last date of filing nominations was June 8. The BJP's third candidate is Mahesh Kewat. The complaint was filed by senior BJP leader and Minister in the Mohan Yadav government, Kailash Vijayvargiya. The complaint contended that a

case involving Natarajan is pending before a Telangana court and was not disclosed in her nomination affidavit.

Natarajan alleged that the BJP is "muzzling democracy and the Constitution," saying that what was earlier limited to "vote theft" has now become "seat theft."

She said, "When the number of members was not adequate, and the BJP fielded third candidate, it all started from there, and we started to understand that they are doing the politics of muzzling the democracy, constitution."

After the poll body's decision which came as a shock to the Congress, the party broke out in vehement protests.

"The allegation of any error or non-disclosure in her nomination is complete humbug and a desperate attempt to snatch a seat from the INC... They stooped so low as to reject her nomination when they realised that their dirty tricks to compromise our INC MLAs is going to fail. This shows the BJP's hollow commitment to the Constitution and democracy. At every step of the way, they are hell-bent on Vote Chori - one way or another," read a post from Congress general secretary KC Venugopal.

"The BJP is engaged in breaking all norms of political decency to snatch the Congress seat. First, they deliberately denied permission for the flight carrying Congress MLAs to take off for a long time. Second, they maliciously filed an objection against the nomination of Congress candidate Meenakshi Natarajan. And then, BJP leaders created a ruckus in the assembly premises," former Chief Minister Kamal Nath said in a post.

Congress's Madhya Pradesh in-charge, Harish Chaudhary, declared that no case had been filed against Natarajan and the BJP was bringing up such allegations only to harass her. Natarajan had received a show-cause notice from the court, and it was not necessary to mention it in the affidavit, since information needs to be provided only when a police case is filed, he said.

In the 230-member Madhya Pradesh Assembly, a Rajya Sabha candidate needs 58 votes to win. The BJP, with around 165 MLAs, can comfortably elect its two nominees -- Tarun Chugh and Rajneesh Agarwal -- using 116 votes. That still leaves it with roughly 47 to 49 surplus votes.

The Congress has 65 MLAs, which was enough strength to send Meenakshi Natarajan to the Upper House.

J'hand HC

The court stressed that survivors must be treated with dignity and should not face intimidation, coercion or undue pressure dur-

BRICS meeting begins in Indore

Food security and agri cooperation being discussed

OUR CORRESPONDENT

INDORE: A five-day meeting of BRICS member countries began on Tuesday in Indore, focusing on issues such as food security, climate-friendly smart agriculture and farmer welfare.

A senior official from the Department of Agriculture said issues such as food security, the impact of climate change on agriculture, and enhancing cooperation in the sector are being discussed.

Officials from BRICS member countries participated in the first round.

"The meeting is discussing common issues in the agricultural sector of BRICS countries to enhance cooperation and jointly address the problems faced by farmers. These include issues such as the impact of climate change on agriculture and financing for the agricultural sector," Ajit Kumar Sahu, Joint Secretary (International Cooperation) of the Department of Agriculture and Farmers Wel-

Officials from BRICS member countries participated in the first round

fare, told reporters.

He said BRICS countries are home to nearly half the world's population, and therefore, ensuring food security in these countries and maintaining it in the future is an important common topic of discussion.

"Agriculture ensures food security and nutritional security. Therefore, agricultural development is essential," Sahu added.

He said the meeting also discussed issues related to the exchange of agricultural technology and increasing trade among BRICS countries.

According to Sahu, approximately eight meetings had been held across four sessions of the Agriculture Working Group, and the fifth session, which began in Indore, is being held in person.

As part of this conference,

held under India's BRICS chairmanship, the Agriculture Working Group will hold deliberations till June 11 with officials from member countries.

The Joint Secretary said that a meeting of the Agriculture Ministers of BRICS and its partner countries will be held on June 12 and 13.

Earlier in the day, India's Department of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare Secretary Atish Chandra led the inaugural session of the meeting.

BRICS is an intergovernmental organisation comprising 11 major emerging economies: Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, and Indonesia.

The five-day conference will discuss topics such as food security, farmer welfare, nutrition, climate-friendly smart agriculture, facilitating international agricultural trade, supply chains, digital agriculture, research, knowledge exchange, artificial intelligence (AI), and robotics, officials said.

Interim allocation of Rs 95,692 crore announced by Centre

J&K: Rs 6,800-crore Zojila tunnel project achieves breakthrough in excavation work

Modi 3.0 anniversary: Congress jabs govt with 'promise versus reality' document

Israel envoy hails growing India-Israel partnership

Reuven Azar cites technology and infrastructure as new pillars

This feat was attributed to the efforts of its citizens and technological advancements.

UP govt plans housing, health cover for Triple Talaq, acid attack survivors

According to officials, eligible beneficiaries will be covered under the Prime Minister Awas Yojana, Chief Minister Awas Yojana, Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana and the Chief Minister Jan Arogya Yojana.

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government is preparing to extend housing and health insurance benefits to women affected by triple talaq and acid attacks as part of its efforts to strengthen

CENTRE FOR DISTANCE & ONLINE EDUCATION (CDOE)
UNIVERSITY OF JAMMU, JAMMU-180006
www.distanceeducationju.in
(NAAC Accredited A++, Category-I University)

Admission Notification of
Online Programmes (M.Com Online & M.A English Online)
Sem-I Session 2026-27

It is notified for the information of all concerned that the admission to Online programmes (M.Com Online & M.A English Online) Semester Ist for the session 2026-27 being offered by the Centre for Distance & Online Education, University of Jammu, Jammu shall commence from **10-06-2026 to 09-07-2026**

All the desirous candidates are requested to refer the Websites:
www.jammuuniversity.ac.in , www.distanceeducationju.in for details.

The online application form can be filled through the Website:
www.distanceeducationju.in

No. CDOE/PG/OL/26/143
Dated: 08-06-2026

Sd/-
DIRECTOR

DIP No:DIP/1-969-P/26

'DRESSING UP MASSACRE AS MILITARY OP DOES NOT ABSOLVE PERPETRATOR'

India raps Pakistan over Afghanistan airstrikes

UNITED NATIONS: India launched a strong attack on Pakistan at the United Nations Security Council, accusing it of violating Afghanistan's sovereignty through military airstrikes and imposing what it described as "trade and transit terrorism" on the landlocked nation.

Speaking during a UNSC meeting on the situation in Afghanistan on Monday, India's Permanent Representative to the UN, Harish Parvathaneni, condemned Pakistan's cross-border military actions, saying that attempts to portray civilian killings as counter-terrorism operations could not conceal the human cost of the attacks. "Dressing up a massacre as a military operation does not absolve the perpetrator. Killing, maiming and orphaning civilians is not counter-terrorism," Parvathaneni said, accusing Pakistan of causing widespread civilian suffering



Harish Parvathaneni delivers India's statement at the UN Security Council on the situation in Afghanistan

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Attempts to portray civilian killings as counter-terrorism operations could not conceal the human cost of the attacks, India's Permanent Representative to the UN Harish Parvathaneni said
- » Apart from security concerns, India criticised Pakistan's restrictions on Afghan trade and transit access

through repeated airstrikes on Afghan territory.

Citing data from the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), he said 372 civilians were killed and 397 injured during the first three months of the year. He noted that a majority of the casualties occurred during the holy month of Ramadan,

describing the violence as particularly reprehensible.

"No faith, no law and no morality can justify such actions," he told the Council, adding that the strikes constituted a blatant violation of international law, the UN Charter and the principle of state sovereignty.

Parvathaneni also accused

Pakistan of hypocrisy, saying it publicly invoked international law and Islamic solidarity while simultaneously carrying out military operations that caused civilian casualties. "Blaming neighbours for its own failures is an old Pakistani habit. This attempt to hoodwink the world will fail," he said.

India further rejected Paki-

stan's decision to refer to militant groups operating within its borders as "Fitna al Hindustan", describing the terminology as state-sponsored misinformation designed to foster hostility towards India.

The term has been used by Pakistani authorities in reference to Balochistan-based insurgent groups.

Calling it the product of an "organised factory of hate", Parvathaneni alleged that elements within Pakistan's establishment were seeking to maintain a climate of perpetual antagonism with India in order to divert attention from domestic political and economic challenges. In a pointed remark, he also referred to Pakistan's 27th Constitutional Amendment, passed last year, saying it reflected the military's growing influence over the country's political system.

Apart from security concerns, India criticised Pakistan's

restrictions on Afghan trade and transit access. Describing the measures as "trade and transit terrorism", Parvathaneni said Afghan traders were suffering due to Islamabad's denial of overland access despite Afghanistan being a landlocked developing country.

He argued that such actions violated international obligations, including UN declarations relating to landlocked developing countries, as well as World Trade Organisation norms. India, he said, had instead offered tariff-free access for Afghan exports, established a dedicated air freight corridor and issued hundreds of long-term business visas to Afghan traders.

"The cynical closure of access for this landlocked country is a clear weaponisation of its trade and transit vulnerabilities," he said, urging the international community to condemn such practices. AGENCIES

SHAH LAUNCHES LPMS

India takes key step towards intelligent border management



NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Tuesday inaugurated the Land Port Management System (LPMS), describing it as a significant step towards building a modern, technology-driven and secure border management framework for the country.

Speaking at the launch, Shah said the integration of LPMS with Smart Borders would strengthen monitoring and management at land border crossings while improving coordination among multiple agencies operating at these points. The system is expected to streamline trade and passenger movement by enabling seamless data sharing and reducing procedural delays. It will also help curb unauthorised cross-border movements through enhanced information exchange and real-time monitoring.

Highlighting the importance of land ports, Shah said India currently operates 15 land ports and plans to establish 11 more over the next three years. These facilities not only facilitate trade and transit but also contribute to border security, regional development and employment generation in frontier areas. He said the development of land ports promotes economic activity in border regions, reducing migration and strengthening

local communities. The expansion of border infrastructure, he added, forms an important part of the government's long-term strategy for balanced regional growth and national security.

Shah noted that LPMS has digitised nearly 90 per cent of processes that were previously paper-based through a single integrated platform. The system has reduced processing and clearance times by 40 to 60 per cent, making border operations more efficient and transparent. Calling LPMS a key component of India's intelligent border management strategy, Shah said it would enhance operational efficiency while improving coordination among stakeholders.

He also highlighted the sharp rise in trade through land ports over the past decade. According to him, trade volume handled through land ports has increased from Rs 5,000 crore in 2014 to Rs 83,000 crore at present, registering a sixteen-fold growth during the tenure of the Narendra Modi government.

The system enables real-time data exchange among several agencies. It integrates platforms such as ICEGATE, the motor vehicle system, the CBIC, the BSF, the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT), the UIDAI and the Unified Logistics Interface Platform (ULIP).

Haryana sets Dec 2027 deadline for Yamuna pollution control projects

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Secretary Anurag Rastogi on Tuesday directed departments concerned to expedite sewage treatment, industrial effluent management and pollution-control projects aimed at improving the water quality of the Yamuna and its tributary drains.

Chairing a high-level review meeting on the Yamuna Action Plan, Rastogi said the Haryana government is committed to keeping the river clean through a coordinated, technology-driven and time-bound approach. He instructed officials to ensure that all ongoing and proposed projects are completed by December 31, 2027.



Haryana Chief Secretary Anurag Rastogi chairs a review meeting

The review highlighted progress on new sewage treatment plants (STPs), common effluent treatment plants (CETPs), micro-STPs and infrastructure for tapping untreated wastewater before it reaches natural water bodies. Haryana State Pollution

Control Board Chairman Vinay Pratap Singh informed the meeting that projects involving more than 425 million litres per day (MLD) of additional sewage treatment capacity and over 150 MLD of industrial effluent treatment capacity are at various stages of approval, tendering and execution. Among the major initiatives is the upgradation of the 10-MLD STP at Jattal Road in Panipat to treat both domestic sewage and industrial effluents. Plans for six micro-STPs in Karnal villages were also reviewed to curb the discharge of untreated grey water into drains.

Officials discussed proposed CETPs at Nathupur and Kundli in Sonipat and expansion of the Rathdhana STP.

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Tuesday announced a series of measures aimed at strengthening rural infrastructure, sanitation and local governance, including the provision of tractor-trolleys, drivers and waste collection workers in every village to improve waste management systems.

Addressing the state-level Sashakt Panchayat Samaroh in Panchkula, Saini said the government is also working on waste-to-energy projects to ensure sustainable disposal of rural waste. During the event, he inaugurated LED street lighting along the peripheral roads (phirnis) of 179 villages across 17 districts at a cost of Rs 23.21 crore. He also dedicated 350 e-Atal libraries built in 17

districts with an investment of Rs 44 crore. Saini transferred Rs 1,056.75 crore directly to the accounts of Panchayati Raj Institutions for development works and honoured six gram panchayats under the Jagrit Gram Awards for excellence in development, sanitation and governance. The award-winning panchayats received a total prize money of Rs 1.66 crore.

Highlighting the role of villages in nation-building, Saini said India's democratic traditions have long been sustained through village panchayats and that Haryana is committed to making villages active partners in development. He noted that more than Rs 2,697 crore has been released under various schemes to strengthen rural

infrastructure and governance.

The CM also announced relief for families residing on village shamlat land for over 20 years. Such families will now be eligible to apply for ownership rights under prescribed rules until January 16 next year. Applicants will be required to pay one-and-a-half times the land value calculated at the collector rate prevailing in 2004.

Saini said over 98 per cent of villages in Haryana have achieved ODF Plus status and expressed confidence that all villages would become ODF Plus Model Villages by October 2. He also highlighted the government's decision to increase the financial limit for development works undertaken by gram panchayats from Rs 5 lakh to Rs 21 lakh. MPOST

'Flight ops from Ambala airport to begin soon'

CHANDIGARH: Union Minister of State for Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution and Social Justice & Empowerment B.L. Verma on Tuesday expressed confidence that flight operations from the newly built Domestic Airport (Civil Enclave) at Ambala Cantonment would begin soon, making it the country's 165th operational airport.

After inspecting the facility along with Haryana Energy, Transport and Labour Minister Anil Vij, Verma said India's aviation infrastructure has witnessed rapid expansion under the BJP-led government. He noted that while only 74 airports were operational before the BJP came to power, the number has now risen to 164.

Praising the development work in Ambala Cantonment, Verma said a new chapter of progress was being written in the constituency under Vij's leadership. He also congratulated the state government, officials and engineers associated with the project.

During the visit, Vij informed the Union Minister that Ambala Cantonment houses one of the country's oldest and most strategically significant military airbases. Owing to its importance, the British had also developed an airbase in Ambala during their rule. He said the runway is equipped with modern facilities that allow aircraft operations round the clock and in all weather conditions. Developed over nearly 20 acres, the domestic airport is expected to emerge as a major aviation hub for passengers from Haryana, Punjab, Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and neighbouring regions.

Vij highlighted that Ambala Cantonment is already one of North India's busiest railway junctions, handling around 276 train arrivals and departures daily.

He further informed that several airlines have applied to operate flights from the airport and that the Civil Aviation Ministry has found no technical hurdles to commencing services. MPOST

Kejriwal, CM Mann condemn ED raids on traders in Punjab

CHANDIGARH: The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and the Punjab government on Tuesday strongly criticised fresh Enforcement Directorate (ED) raids on traders in the state, alleging that central agencies were being misused to intimidate the business community for political purposes.

AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal claimed that the BJP-led Centre was targeting traders through repeated ED action and sought to reassure Punjab's business community. In a post on X, Kejriwal said traders should not panic, asserting that the Punjab government and the people of the state stood firmly with them.

"The ED Party is once again conducting raids on traders in Punjab. There is no need to panic. The entire Punjab and

“The ED Party is once again conducting raids on traders in Punjab. There is no need to panic. The entire Punjab and the Punjab government are with you”

the Punjab government are with you," he said.

Kejriwal also took a swipe at the BJP and the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) amid speculation about a possible alliance between the two parties in Punjab. He further criticised the Congress, alleging that it had come out in support of the BJP on the issue.

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann echoed Kejriwal's remarks, describing traders as the backbone of the state's economy and accusing the Centre of using investigative agencies to exert political pressure. "Punjab's traders have made a significant contribution to the state's economic growth. Attempts to harass them through central agencies will not be tolerated. The Punjab government stands firmly with the trading community," Mann said.

Senior AAP leader Manish Sisodia also attacked the Centre, alleging that excessive reliance on investigative agencies was hurting economic growth and entrepreneurship. He said India needed an "innovation economy, not an ED economy." MPOST

EXPERTS CALL FOR URGENT ACTION

'Unscientific growth threatens Himalayas'

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Experts, policymakers and environmental practitioners from 11 Himalayan states and Union Territories on Monday raised alarm over the mounting impact of climate change and unsustainable development on the fragile ecology of the Indian Himalayan Region (IHR), calling for urgent policy reforms and community-led development strategies.

The concerns were voiced during a day-long consultation organised by the Integrated Mountain Initiative (IMI) and Systemiq, a London-based climate action organisation, at the India Habitat Centre in the national capital.

Participants criticised the prevailing development model in the Himalayan region as "directionless, unscientific and community-insensitive", warning that it is accelerating ecological degradation and increasing vulnerability to natural disasters. They stressed that unchecked infrastructure expansion, coupled with climate change, is placing enormous pressure on mountain ecosystems and local

KEY POINTS

- » The concerns were voiced during a day-long consultation organised by the Integrated Mountain Initiative and Systemiq, a London-based climate action organisation
- » Participants criticised the prevailing development model in the Himalayan region as 'directionless, unscientific and community-insensitive'



» They stressed that unchecked infrastructure expansion, coupled with climate change, is placing enormous pressure on mountain ecosystems and local communities

communities.

Unregulated tourism emerged as a key concern during the discussions. Experts noted that growing tourist footfalls are straining local resources, polluting rivers and forests, and affecting the cultural and spiritual character of Himalayan destinations. Sacred sites, they said, are increasingly being disrupted by littering, noise pollution and behaviour that disregards local traditions and sensitivities.

Former IMI President Sushil Ramola urged the NITI Aayog to formulate a com-

prehensive national policy on Himalayan tourism that balances economic benefits with ecological sustainability and cultural preservation. Former NITI Aayog advisor V.K. Jain called for a distinct "Himalayan Narrative" in policymaking, arguing that development in the mountains must prioritise conservation, ecology and community welfare rather than purely commercial considerations.

Former Sikkim MP P.D. Rai highlighted demographic challenges facing the region, including declining local pop-

ulations and growing dependence on migrant labour. He cautioned that unmanaged demographic changes could create social tensions in the future. IMI President Ramesh Negi advocated the immediate revival of the Council of Himalayan States, established in 2018 to provide a common policy platform for Himalayan states and Union Territories. He also called for a mandatory Himalayan construction code to ensure that infrastructure projects are designed in line with the region's ecological and geological realities.

Representing Nagaland, Amba Jamir criticised development agencies for overlooking traditional knowledge systems and environmentally sustainable local practices. He urged a review of large-scale plantation drives involving commercial crops such as rubber and palm oil, stressing that local communities must remain central to development planning.

Systemiq Team Leader Arushi Chopra presented a framework for attracting private investment into projects that combine economic growth with conservation and community interests.

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Tuesday reviewed preparations for the June 21 NEET-UG re-test and assured candidates that measures have been put in place to ensure the examination is conducted smoothly, securely and without errors.

He also appealed to the candidates to focus on their studies, asserting that the government is taking extra precautions this time, from question paper setting to their delivery at the examination centres.

The minister assessed the readiness of the examination system and reviewed the measures being undertaken to ensure the smooth, secure and transparent conduct of the NEET-UG re-test.

During the review meet-



ing at the headquarters of the National Testing Agency (NTA), Pradhan emphasised the importance of maintaining the highest standards of confidentiality and integrity throughout the examination process, sources said.

He said special attention has been given to safeguarding every stage of the process, from the preparation of question papers to the secure transportation and timely delivery of examination materials to

More than 20 booked for vandalising non-veg dhaba in UP

MUZAFFARNAGAR: More than 20 activists, including the district president of the youth wing of a Hindu outfit, have been booked for vandalising a non-vegetarian roadside eatery in Muzaaffarnagar district.

The dhaba is located near Sisona village on the Delhi-Dehradun national highway under Chapar Police Station area. Circle Officer Ravishankar said that acting on the complaint of the dhaba owner, Azad, the police have registered a case against more than 20 activists of the Hindu Raksha Dal, including the district president of its youth wing, Hemant Sharma, for vandalising the dhaba on Monday.

According to Azad, over two dozen people "entered his dhaba on Monday, removed the flex board and burnt it. They also beat up his employees and damaged property, threatening that the non-vegetarian dhaba will not be allowed on the path of the Kawad Yatra", which will begin after a few months. MPOST

Pradhan assures aspirants of error-free re-NEET

MPOST BUREAU

Ministries, NTA, NMC officials set to face parliamentary panel today

NEW DELHI: Top officials of the Health and Education ministries, National Testing Agency and National Medical Commission will brief a parliamentary panel on Wednesday over the conduct of the NEET-UG re-examination on June 21.

The Department-related Parliamentary Standing Committee on Health and Family Welfare has summoned the secretaries of Higher Education and Health, besides top officials of the NTA and NMC, to brief the panel on the NEET re-exam. This is the third parliamentary panel before whom the top officials of the ministries and NTA (National Testing Agency) and NMC (National Medical Commission) are appearing. MPOST

centres across the country, they added.

Pradhan also said that meetings have been held under the Cabinet secretary, and all the states have been asked to cooperate with the re-examination process. "The NTA is going to conduct the re-NEET on June 21. We have reviewed

the preparations several times. Today, I visited the NTA headquarters to review the same," Pradhan told reporters.

"From the preparation of question papers to ensuring that they reach the examination centres on time, we have taken additional precautions this time," he added.

CBI arrests two for trafficking Indians to scam centres abroad

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested two alleged key operatives of an international human trafficking syndicate accused of luring Indian citizens to scam centres in Southeast Asia with promises of lucrative overseas jobs and subsequently forcing them into cyber fraud activities.

The accused have been identified as Nipender Chaudhary and Nilesh Narpatsinh Purohit.

According to the CBI, the syndicate targeted Indian job seekers by offering high-paying employment opportunities abroad. Victims were persuaded to travel to Southeast Asian countries with assurances of legitimate jobs and attractive salaries.

However, upon arrival, many were allegedly taken to scam compounds operating primarily in Myanmar and parts of Cambodia, where they were forced to participate in online fraud schemes run by organised criminal networks.

Investigators said victims faced severe restrictions, including confiscation of passports and travel documents, curtailed movement, and physical and psychological abuse. In several instances, families were allegedly forced to pay large sums to secure the release of their relatives.

The probe revealed that Chaudhary allegedly played a key role in facilitating the movement of Indian nationals to Myanmar through Thailand. He is accused of coordinating travel arrangements and transit routes used to transport victims from India to scam centres.

According to officials, victims were flown to Bangkok and then moved to Mae Sot in Thailand before being illegally taken across the Thailand-Myanmar border and handed over to operators of scam compounds.

Purohit, meanwhile, allegedly operated from a scam centre near the Thailand-Myanmar border and coordinated a network of agents across India on behalf of the syndicate.



EDITORIAL
POLITICS OVER
HISTORY

The proposal to rename Barkatullah University in Bhopal as Ma Vagdevi University and to alter Bhopal's historical nomenclature to Bhojpal has reignited a familiar debate in India: where should the line be drawn between honouring cultural traditions and preserving historical memory? While governments and institutions have the legal authority to rename public places and institutions, legality alone cannot settle questions of history, fairness and national memory. The issue is not merely about a university's name; it is about how a nation chooses to remember those who helped shape its freedom struggle.

Prof. Barkatullah occupies a significant, though often underappreciated, place in India's anti-colonial movement. Born in Bhopal, he was among the founding members of the Ghadar movement, one of the most ambitious international efforts to challenge British rule. Operating from abroad at a time when political dissent within India faced severe repression, the Ghadar Party mobilised Indian expatriates across continents and transformed discontent into organised resistance. Barkatullah played a crucial role in building networks connecting Indians living in North America, Europe, West Asia, and beyond. His involvement in the formation of the Provisional Government of India in Kabul in 1915 marked one of the earliest attempts to establish an alternative Indian political authority outside British control. Long before the Indian National Army emerged under Subhas Chandra Bose, revolutionaries like Barkatullah were laying the groundwork for an international struggle against colonialism.

To remove such a name from a university is not merely an administrative exercise. It sends a message, intentional or otherwise, about whose contributions are worthy of remembrance and whose are not. Historical figures cannot be judged solely through the prism of contemporary political preferences. Freedom fighters came from different regions, religions, castes and ideological backgrounds. Their collective sacrifice created the foundation of modern India. Selectively celebrating some while sidelining others weakens the inclusive spirit of the freedom movement itself.

Supporters of the proposal argue that naming the university after Ma Vagdevi, another name for Goddess Saraswati, would better reflect Indian cultural heritage. There is nothing objectionable in honouring Saraswati, who has long been revered as the embodiment of knowledge, wisdom and learning. Educational institutions across the country draw inspiration from her symbolism. The question, however, is whether such recognition must come at the cost of displacing an existing name associated with a distinguished son of the soil and a respected freedom fighter. India is vast enough, and its educational landscape expansive enough, to accommodate both cultural reverence and historical remembrance.

Indeed, the debate raises a larger concern about the growing tendency to view history through narrow political lenses. Renaming institutions may generate immediate headlines and satisfy certain constituencies, but it often contributes little to improving educational standards, research output or academic excellence. Universities derive their prestige not merely from the names they bear but from the quality of learning they foster. If the objective is to honour the goddess of learning, the most meaningful tribute would be to strengthen the academic environment, promote critical inquiry, encourage scholarship and uphold intellectual freedom. These are values that Saraswati symbolises far more profoundly than any nameplate on a building.

There is also a constitutional dimension to the issue. India's founding vision rests on the principle that the nation belongs equally to all its citizens, irrespective of faith, language, caste or region. Public institutions, especially universities, should reflect this inclusive ethos. They are spaces where history is studied, debated and understood in all its complexity. Altering names associated with nationally significant figures risks creating the impression that historical recognition is contingent upon contemporary political currents rather than enduring contributions to the nation.

Equally troubling is the precedent such changes create. If every change in political power results in the renaming of institutions, roads, cities and public spaces, the country risks entering a cycle of perpetual revisionism. Historical memory becomes unstable, shaped less by scholarship and more by electoral calculations. Future generations may inherit a fragmented understanding of the past, with important figures disappearing from public consciousness not because their contributions lacked merit but because they no longer fit prevailing political narratives.

This is not an argument against new names, new institutions or new symbols. Nations evolve, and public recognition should evolve with them. However, such recognition should expand the circle of remembrance rather than shrink it. If there is a desire to honour Ma Vagdevi, new universities, research centres, scholarships or institutions dedicated to education can be established in her name. Such initiatives would enrich India's academic and cultural landscape without erasing an existing historical legacy.

At its heart, the controversy is about more than Barkatullah or Bhopal. It is about whether India chooses to preserve a plural and inclusive memory of its freedom struggle or allow that memory to be narrowed by contemporary politics. Universities, of all places, should resist such narrowing. They should stand as custodians of history, inquiry and intellectual honesty. Before any decision is taken, policymakers would do well to remember that names are not merely labels. They are repositories of collective memory, reminders of sacrifice and bridges between generations. Once erased, those connections become far harder to restore.

BHARAT
KI SOCH



ANIL RAJPUT

THE WRITER IS
CHAIRPERSON,
BHARAT KI SOCH

Shakuni stands apart not because he lacked intelligence, but because he used it without moral restraint

Cost of Intellect Without Dharma

Through Shakuni, the Mahabharata reminds us that intellect, influence and strategy become destructive when they are not anchored in conscience, restraint and moral responsibility

The Mahabharata does not celebrate only the lives of those who stood as ideals of courage, sacrifice and righteousness but also the stories of those whose abilities, though undeniable, became destructive because they were not aligned with dharma. Shakuni belongs to this engaging category. He was sharp, observant, patient and politically alert. He understood people, power, ambition and weakness. Yet his life was fraught with uncertainty because his intellect did not serve truth and justice. Rather, it served resentment, manipulation and revenge. Through Shakuni, ancient civilisational wisdom reminds us that talent alone is never enough but becomes meaningful only when it is governed by conscience. Intellect without dharma may occasionally impress, but it ultimately destroys trust, families, institutions and the moral order that sustains society.

Shakuni, the prince of Gandhara and brother of Gandhari, entered the story of Hastinapur through family ties. As the maternal uncle of Duryodhan, he held a position of influence within the Kuru household. Such a position was not ordinary. In any family, court or institution, those who stand close to the young and ambitious carry a deep responsibility. They can either calm insecurity or sharpen it. They can either guide emotion towards discipline or turn it into grievance. Shakuni chose the second path. He saw Duryodhan's jealousy towards the Pandavas, his desire for supremacy and his inability to accept their merit. Instead of correcting this weakness, Shakuni cultivated it. Instead of reminding him that power must be earned through character and responsibility, he indulged his illusion that power could be secured through deceit.

This is one of the first lessons from Shakuni's story. Influence is never neutral. Every word spoken by a mentor, advisor, elder or friend either strengthens the moral fibre of another person or weakens it. Shakuni's failure was not merely that he acted wrongly himself, but that he became an active force in the moral decline of someone younger and more powerful. He knew the strengths, weaknesses, fears and motivations of those around him, reminding us that careful observation of human behaviour often carries more power than technical skill alone. In families, institutions, offices and public life, people who advise leaders often shape decisions more deeply than those who hold visible authority.

Shakuni's intellect was strategic, but strategy without ethics is also dangerous. He did not rely on brute force. He thought several moves ahead, anticipated consequences and prepared



The Mahabharata does not condemn intelligence. It condemns intelligence divorced from dharma

for different outcomes. His calmness became a competitive advantage, reminding us that emotional control improves decision-making while panic clouds judgement. He knew when to speak, when to provoke, when to wait and when to act. The Mahabharat does not celebrate this cleverness but exposes its emptiness. True wisdom is not the ability to defeat another person through calculation but the ability to recognise what is right, even when wrongdoing appears more profitable. Shakuni teaches us that cleverness and wisdom are not the same. Cleverness seeks advantage, while wisdom seeks harmony and stability. Cleverness may create temporary victory, but wisdom shapes and protects the future.

His role in the game of dice remains one of the most revealing episodes of the Mahabharat. The dice game was not merely a contest of chance but became a moral collapse disguised as procedure. The language of rules remained, but the spirit of justice was absent. Shakuni used skill and deception to draw Yudhishtir deeper into loss, until kingdom, wealth, brothers and even Draupadi were dragged into humiliation. This episode reminds us that institutions cannot survive on technical legality alone. A process may appear valid, yet still become unjust if its purpose is corrupted. Rules without fairness become instruments of exploitation and procedure without conscience becomes a weapon in the hands of the manipulative.

This lesson carries great relevance for leadership. In any organisation, the misuse of process can be as harm-

ful as open wrongdoing. Decisions can be made to appear proper while being guided by jealousy, vendetta or personal gain. Shakuni's conduct shows how dangerous it is when intelligence is used to exploit loopholes rather than uphold principles. Ethical leadership requires moral intent. It requires the courage to ask not only whether something can be done, but whether it should be done. The absence of this question is where decline begins.

There is also a deeper moral lesson in Shakuni's relationship with grievance. Many later traditions remember him through the lens of pain, injury and revenge. Whether one accepts every detail of those events or not, the moral point remains powerful. His personal life is associated with deep family suffering, and his story reminds us that adversity can build capacity when guided by purpose. Yet human beings may experience humiliation, loss or injustice, but suffering does not give anyone the right to destroy the lives of others. Pain can deepen character when it is held with discipline, but it can corrupt character when it becomes a permanent justification for vengeance. Shakuni allowed resentment to become his purpose. Once that happened, his intellect no longer served healing, reconciliation or justice. It served destruction.

The ethical failure of Shakuni also lies in his inability to distinguish loyalty from moral blindness. He was loyal to Duryodhan, but his loyalty did not elevate him. It pushed him further into adharma. Loyalty is not proved by supporting every desire of those we love

or serve. Loyalty is proved by guiding them away from wrongdoing, even when such guidance is uncomfortable. Shakuni gave Duryodhan confidence without correction, strategy without restraint and support without truth. His influence over Duryodhan shows that ideas can be more powerful than force, and that influence without responsibility can overpower judgment. Every leader needs people who can speak honestly, especially when ambition becomes excessive.

The eventual consequence of Shakuni's actions was not victory, but devastation. The humiliation of the Pandavas and Draupadi did not end the conflict. It deepened it. The apparent success of deceit became the seed of the war at Kurukshetra. Success achieved through manipulation carries within it the certainty of future collapse. Wrongdoing may appear effective in the moment, but it creates debts that time will eventually recover. Shakuni may have won the game of dice, but he lost the larger battle of dharma. His methods brought ruin not only upon his opponents, but upon those he claimed to support.

For modern society, Shakuni's story is a reminder that intellect must be placed in service of responsibility. Education, strategy, political skill, legal knowledge, communication and influence are powerful tools, but none of them are inherently virtuous. Their moral worth depends on the purpose they serve. When intellect serves truth, it builds institutions. When it serves ego, it corrodes them. When strategy is guided by dharma, it creates order. When strategy abandons dharma, it becomes manipulation.

Shakuni therefore remains one of the Mahabharat's most important cautionary figures. From him, we learn the value of strategic thinking, resilience, emotional control and understanding human behaviour, but also the danger of allowing resentment and ambition to overpower values. Intelligence needs integrity, strategy needs purpose and influence needs responsibility. The lesson of Shakuni is that the sharpest mind can become a source of ruin if it is not governed by moral clarity. Extraordinary intelligence can achieve remarkable things, but only character ensures that such achievements endure. His story reminds us that greatness is not created by cleverness alone, and that victory without righteousness is only another form of defeat. In the end, Shakuni teaches us that intellect must bow to dharma, because when it refuses to do so, it places families, institutions and society itself on the path of destruction.

Views expressed are personal

BEYOND
TRANSFERS



RAAVI BIRBAL

THE WRITER IS
A PRACTISING
ADVOCATE IN THE
SUPREME COURT
AND HIGH COURT
OF DELHI

Judicious use of legal provisions can curb inefficiency, strengthen accountability, and deter administrative non-performance

India's Crisis Of Accountability

Every major fire triggers outrage and promises of reform, but unless accountability is fixed and non-performing officials face consequences, tragedies born of negligence will continue to recur

Recent fire incidents in Delhi, as well as other such occurrences, will soon be forgotten, and public attention will shift to another news story. Yet, even after such tragedies, try calling a municipal body and one is likely to keep getting transferred from DE to AE, to JE, to Executive Engineer, and so on. Then there will invariably be a long lunch break, tea break, holiday, leave, weekend, or some other reason for inaction. Of course, one must not forget the challenge of finding official phone numbers that have not worked for years. Citizens are often left navigating outdated contact details, unanswered calls, and a maze of red tape and delays, reflecting a serious lack of accountability and responsiveness in the system. In many cases, people spend days trying to get a simple grievance addressed, only to encounter bureaucratic hurdles at every step.

Instances of non-responsiveness must be dealt with severely to create a strong deterrent and ensure accountability at all levels. If doctors can face consequences for negligence in treating patients, hospitals can be penalised for lapses, courts can point out shortcomings in the legal system, and top government officials can be publicly criticised, roasted, and trolled ruthlessly, why do errant executives of departments directly handling such issues often escape accountability? There appears to be an institutional reluctance to fix responsibility where it is most urgently required, and this culture of impunity must end.

The need of the hour is continuous monitoring and strict implementation. Complaint details should be made publicly available on official websites, along with real-time complaint status updates. Records of unanswered calls, pending complaints, response times, and action taken should also be transparently displayed on official portals. Such measures would enhance accountability, improve responsiveness, and act as a deterrent against non-performance. Unless this



Instances of non-responsiveness must be dealt with severely to create a strong deterrent and ensure accountability at all levels

issue is addressed and cured, such incidents will continue to occur. Of course, the impact of any corrective action should not fall on the poor or vulnerable sections of society, but on the real culprits who fail to perform their duties despite being entrusted with public responsibility.

Most importantly, our legal framework contains several provisions, the judicious use of which can energise the administrative machinery, address inefficiency, and at times even serve as a deterrent against non-performance. Time-bound disciplinary action against officials who have slept over their duties or ignored mandatory checks for years is essential to ensure accountability and restore public confidence in the system. Apart from time-bound disciplinary action, the administration and courts, in a catena of judgments, have consistently emphasised the necessity of "chopping off dead wood" — that is, removing inefficiency from the system. One of the key provisions in this regard is Fundamental Rule 56(j), which empowers the government to order compulsory retirement in the public interest.

In *Union of India vs. Santosh Kumar Tiwari* (2024), the Supreme Court, inter alia, held that compulsory retirement is a well-accepted method of removing dead wood from the cadre without affecting an employee's entitlement to retirement benefits, if otherwise payable. To keep the force efficient, weeding out undesirable elements is essential and is a facet of administrative control, the Apex Court observed. The objective is to cure lethargy within the system and maintain efficiency, initiative, and integrity within the service. Such actions are often invoked in the public interest to eliminate inefficiency and safeguard institutional standards. They also aim to dispense with the services of those whose integrity is in doubt, thereby upholding purity, accountability, and public confidence in administration.

The recent fire incident calls for stricter disciplinary action against those who remained inactive and failed to discharge their responsibilities diligently. It also warrants a comprehensive review of the role and conduct of all those involved over the years, so that accountability is

fixed, systemic lapses are not repeated, and a strong deterrent is created. If the role of each individual is thoroughly examined through a detailed enquiry, including any repeated instances of non-performance, negligence, collusion, misconduct, or irregularities committed not just recently but over several years, it would serve as a powerful warning to others in the future. It would reinforce the principle that officials cannot escape accountability merely by being transferred or reassigned, and that wrongdoing will be investigated and acted upon regardless of the passage of time. At the same time, innocent officials should not be punished or made scapegoats for failures attributable to others.

A robust legal framework is required to clearly provide that investigations and disciplinary proceedings may be initiated and continued irrespective of whether the concerned official remains posted in the department or has since been transferred, retired, or moved elsewhere. Public officials must remain answerable for their acts of commission and omission. Officials should also be under a continuing statutory obligation to maintain proper records of inspections, observations, and actions taken whenever irregularities come to their notice. Where no action is taken despite awareness of violations, the reasons for such inaction should be recorded in writing and preserved for future scrutiny. This would promote transparency, facilitate accountability, and allow us to address responsibility later if needed.

A strong, transparent administrative framework with accountability, continuous monitoring, and effective implementation is the solution. Only when responsibility is fixed, records are maintained, and inaction carries real consequences will public institutions become more responsive and capable of preventing tragedies that continue to claim lives despite repeated warnings and lessons from the past.

Views expressed are personal



SECTION I: NOTICE INVITING BID (NIB)
GOVERNMENT OF UTTARAKHAND
OFFICE OF EXECUTIVE ENGINEER (FIU),
UTTARAKHAND JAL SANSTHAN, INDRAPRASTH COLONY,
LANE NO-3, NATHANPUR, DEHRADUN
Mobile No: [8979785518, 7088079230] Email Id: eewbfui@gmail.com

NOTICE INVITING BID
(Through E-Procurement Portal only - www.uktenders.gov.in)
Letter No.319/Nivida/2026-27 Dated: 09.06.2026

//E-TENDER NOTICE//
(Through E-Procurement Portal only - www.uktenders.gov.in)
On behalf of the GM(TRM), Uttarakhand Jal Sansthan, Dehradun, Executive Engineer (FIU), Uttarakhand Jal Sansthan, Dehradun (referred to as the "Employer") invites Bids from eligible Bidders for following works (hereinafter referred to as "the Works") through E-Procurement Portal as per the following details:

Bid No.	Name of Work	Bid Security (Earnest Money) (₹)	Cost of bid document (₹)	Completion Period
01	Survey, Supply, Installation Testing and Commissioning (SITC) of Grid Connected On Ground or Suitable Location in The Premises of Scheme Solar PV Power Plant Including All Associated Electrical, Civil and Mechanical Works In Ayudh Vihar, Indraprasth Lane No-3, SGRR Nehrugram Tube Well Under Nathanpur W/s Scheme	153870.00	4000+ 18% GST	6 Months
02	Survey, Supply, Installation Testing and Commissioning (SITC) of Grid Connected On Ground or Suitable Location in The Premises of Scheme Solar PV Power Plant Including All Associated Electrical, Civil and Mechanical Works In Lakkarghat Chowk, Guljar Farm, Mola Plot Tube Well Under Kharak Maf Water Supply Scheme.	145470.00	4000+ 18% GST	6 Months
03	Survey, Supply, Installation Testing and Commissioning (SITC) of Grid Connected On Ground or Suitable Location in The Premises of Scheme Solar PV Power Plant Including All Associated Electrical, Civil and Mechanical Works In Gujronwali Office Campus Under Nathuwawala Water Supply Scheme	118440.00	4000+ 18% GST	6 Months
04	Survey, Supply, Installation Testing and Commissioning (SITC) of Grid Connected On Ground or Suitable Location in The Premises of Scheme Solar PV Power Plant Including All Associated Electrical, Civil and Mechanical Works In Lakkarghat Chowk, Devendra Vihar, Chini Godown Tube Well Under Gumaniwala Water Supply Scheme	166050.00	4000+ 18% GST	6 Months
05	Survey, Supply, Installation Testing and Commissioning (SITC) of Grid Connected On Ground or Suitable Location in The Premises of Scheme Solar PV Power Plant Including All Associated Electrical, Civil and Mechanical Works In Near THDC Gate No-1, Mansa Devi, Amit Gram, Geeta Nagar Gali No-14, Geeta Nagar Smriti Van Tube Well Under Rishikesh Dehat Water Supply Scheme	226590.00	4000+ 18% GST	6 Months

Bid documents of above work shall be uploaded on the e-GPS portal i.e. <http://www.uktenders.gov.in> on or before 30.06.2026 upto 17:00 Hours IST.

Executive Engineer (FIU)

INDIAN DIASPORA GROUPS WELCOME THE RULING

US Court strikes down Trump's \$100,000 fee on new H-1B visas



Hurting country very badly: Trump

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Tuesday criticised the federal court order striking down the \$100,000 H-1B visa fee, saying such actions were hurting the country very badly. "These judges are really giving us a hard time, really crazy. They are giving us a very, very hard time ... they're hurting our country very badly," Trump told reporters in New York after watching the NBA Finals at Madison Square Garden. In September last year, Trump signed a proclamation adding the \$100,000 fee for new H-1B visa applications. AGENCIES

WASHINGTON: Indian diaspora organisations in the US have welcomed the federal court order of striking down the USD 100,000 fee on H-1B visa applications, calling it a fair move to the employment-based immigration system. On Monday, a federal judge ruled that the USD 100,000 fee imposed by US President Donald Trump for H-1B applications was unlawful as it did not have the approval of Congress. The H-1B visa is a non-immigrant visa that allows US companies to employ foreign workers in speciality occupations that require theoretical or technical expertise. The technology companies depend on it to hire tens of thousands of employees each year from countries like India and China. "We welcome the Massachusetts federal court's decision striking down the USD 100,000 H-1B visa fee, which restores predictability and fairness to the employment-based immigration system," Khanderao Kand, Chief of Policy and Strategy at the Foundation for India and Indian Diaspora Studies (FIIDS), told PTI. "All stakeholders connected with H-1B visas will heave a sigh of relief after the court order, but one wonders if this is truly the end of the matter," Sanjeev Joshipura, Executive Director, Indiaspora, told PTI. Kand said the court ruling was appropriate for preserving the US's competitive advantage in innovation, research, and entrepreneurship. AGENCIES

Highlights

» The H-1B visa is a non-immigrant visa that allows US companies to employ foreign workers

» The technology companies depend on it to hire tens of thousands of employees each year from countries like India and China

THE JUDGMENT REINFORCES THE PRINCIPLE THAT MAJOR POLICY CHANGES MUST BE GROUNDED IN STATUTORY AUTHORITY & ECONOMIC REALITIES



OFFICE OF THE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION BHOPAL.
GARDEN SECTION
SECTION 1

NIT No 01 /GS/BMC/2026 Dated-08.06.2026

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER
Online percentage rate bids for the following works are invited from registered contractors and firms of repute fulfilling registration criteria:

S. No.	TENDER ID	Name of Work	Probable Amount of contract	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) (In Rs.)	Cost of Tender Document (In Rs.)	Period of Completion (In Months)
1	2026_UAD_513785_1	CONSTRUCTION OF BALANCE CENTRAL MEDIA SOIL FILLING AND PLANTATION WORK BELOW METRO LINE	18881671/-	Rs. 94408/-	12500/-	06 Months

1. Interested bidders can view the NIT on website <https://www.mptenders.gov.in/>
2. The Bid Document can be purchased only online

Sd/- Pramod Malviya
Executive Engineer
Municipal Corporation, Bhopal

T.N.291/026/027

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय
ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमंडल, रामगढ़

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना
अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा संख्या :- **04/2026-27/RWD/RAMGARH** दिनांक :- **08.06.2026**
कार्यपालक अभियंता, ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमंडल, रामगढ़ द्वारा DMFT योजनान्तर्गत निम्न विवरण के अनुसार e-procurement पद्धति से निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।

क्र० सं०	आईडेंटिफिकेशन संख्या	प्रमंडल	कार्य का नाम	प्राक्कलित राशि	टेंडर कोल	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि
1	RWD/RAMGA RH/07/2026-27	गोला	गोला प्रमंडल अन्तर्गत गोविंदपुर गांव में आदिित महतो के घर से मसरीबेड़ा तक पी0सी0सी0 पथ निर्माण।	8410600	प्रथम	06 माह
2	RWD/RAMGA RH/08/2026-27	गोला	गोला ग्राम कामला में तुलसी दांगी के घर से रोहानीसर गढ़ा तक पी0सी0सी0 पथ एवं नाली निर्माण।	5024300	प्रथम	06 माह
3	RWD/RAMGA RH/09/2026-27	गोला	ग्राम पारसाडीह महतो टोला कालीकरण रोड बजरंग बली मंदिर एवं बरतु करमाली के घर होते हुए नदी तक पी0सी0सी0 पथ एवं गार्डवाल का निर्माण।	6214000	प्रथम	06 माह
4	RWD/RAMGA RH/10/2026-27	दुलमी	ग्राम बोंगासरी (खरनीमारा) से कालीकरण रोड तक पी0सी0सी0 पथ का निर्माण।	7228000	प्रथम	06 माह
5	RWD/RAMGA RH/11/2026-27	रामगढ़	ग्राम पंचायत बालगंज झारखण्ड मोड़ से परसाछापर तक पी0सी0सी0 पथ का निर्माण।	5088300	प्रथम	06 माह

2. वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि:- 11.06.2026
3. ई-निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय:- 25.06.2026 अपराह्न 5.00 बजे तक।
4. निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय:- 27.06.2026 अपराह्न 11.30 बजे।
5. निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम एवं पता:- कार्यपालक अभियंता, ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमंडल, रामगढ़, नयानगर, धुदुवा, बरकाकाना, रामगढ़ झारखण्ड, पिन- 829103
6. ई-निविदा प्रकोष्ठ का दूरभाष सं०- 06553254005
विस्तृत जानकारी के लिए वेबसाइट jharkhandtenders.gov.in में देखा जा सकता है।

विश्वासपाजन
हो/-
कार्यपालक अभियंता
ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग कार्य प्रमंडल, रामगढ़

PR 381928 Rural Work Department (26-27)_D

कार्यालय : जिला परिषद्, चतरा।
(Mail Id- db-chatra@jharkhandmail.gov.in)
(E-mail: districtboardchatra@gmail.com)
(अतिअल्पकालिक ई0निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना)

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या - 18/2026-27 दिनांक: 09.06.2026

1. कार्य की विस्तृत विवरणी: डी.एम.एफ.टी.

क्र.	प्रमंडल	पंचायत	ग्राम	योजना का नाम	प्राक्कलित राशि	परिमाण विवरण का मूल्य	अग्रघन की राशि	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1	Tandwa	Bachra north	Hesatu	Construction of High level RCC Girder bridge over Habuadah Nala	22224077	10000	444500	18 months

1. वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि - 20/06/2026
2. ई-निविदा प्राप्ति की तिथि एवं समय - 22.06.2026 से 29.06.2026 के अपराह्न 5:00 बजे तक
3. निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय - 01.07.2026 पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे।
4. सरकार द्वारा लिए गए निर्णय के आलोक में सभी कागजात के साथ निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रघन की राशि online Mode द्वारा स्वीकार्य होगी।
5. निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रघन की राशि का ई-मुद्रातन जिस खाता से किया जायेगा, उसी खाते में अग्रघन की राशि वापस होगी। अगर खाता को बंद कर दिया जाता है तो उसकी सारी जवाबदेही संबंधित निविदाकार की होगी।
6. निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम एवं पता - जिला अभियंता जिला परिषद् चतरा।
7. ई-निविदा प्रकोष्ठ का दूरभाष सं० - 9835777636
8. विस्तृत जानकारी के लिये वेबसाइट www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in एवं कार्यालय की सूचना पट्ट पर देखा जा सकता है।

जिला अभियंता,
जिला परिषद्, चतरा।

PR 381957 District(26-27)D

CENTRAL RAILWAY
PUNE DIVISION

Open Tender Notice No.: DRM-W-PA-E-Tend-2026-CO-14 Date: 05.06.2026

Divisional Railway Manager (Works), Central Railway, Pune for and on behalf of the President of India, invites Open E-tenders through website www.ireps.gov.in for the work: **Name of Work :** (1) Pune-Development of Railway Hospital at Pune under ADEN/M/Pune. (2) Maintenance of railway health unit at Ghorpadi under ADEN/M/Pune. (3) Modification of existing Pathology laboratory, dialysis center and physiotherapy center etc. in Divisional Railway Hospital at Pune under ADEN/M/Pune. (i) Making of pathway, dome shaped shed from old OPD building to Administrative building and wall for the room No. 11 ii) Boundary wall of hospital behind Administrative building iii) Shed of RO plant on top floor of Administrative building iv) Covered car parking for doctors and officers at DRH Pune near new block. Minor repair of existing billing section v) Construction of dormitory on top floor of old building casually side, for patient's relatives who are coming from out station. (04 rooms total out of which two rooms each for male and female with attached toilets and bathrooms similar to supervisor rest house with scope of kitchen facility). vi) Construction of additional toilet block for female patients in first floor of old building. vii) Shifting of O2 plant which is located in front of main entrance of the hospital to an area behind casualty. viii) Improvement of Ghorpadi medical facility. etc.] (Reinvite) **Adv Cost:-** ₹61616424.21. **EMD:-** ₹ 1232300.00. **Tender closing date and time of aforesaid e-tender:** Upto 15.15 Hrs. Of 23.06.2026. The prospective tenderers are requested to visit the website www.ireps.gov.in for details of tenders & corrigendum, if any. Tenderer may participate in above E-tender electronically through website www.ireps.gov.in only & submission of manual offers against E-tender are not allowed. Manual offers, if submitted, shall neither be opened nor considered. For further enquiry, may contact: Divisional Railway Manager (Works) Office, Central Railway, Pune on Phone No. 020-26105309. Tender who wants to be present at the time of Opening of tenders, he/she may do so. **EXP - 25** **DRM (Works), Pune**
Travel safely, Avoid footboard travelling

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Suresh Kumar S/o Ram Roop R/o Koyla Godam, Near Shiv Mandir, Rajouri Garden, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 1059/2021 U/S 33 Delhi Excise Act, PS Rajouri Garden, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Suresh Kumar** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Suresh Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Suresh Kumar of FIR No. 1059/2021 U/S 33 Delhi Excise Act, PS Rajouri Garden, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **10.07.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Shashank Nandan Bhatt
Judicial Magistrate First Class- 02
West District
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/7420/WD/2026(Court Matter)

CHINESE PREZ CONCLUDES RARE NORTH KOREA VISIT

Important consensus reached with Kim: Xi



Chinese President Xi Jinping and North Korea's Kim Jong Un

BEIJING: Chinese President Xi Jinping on Tuesday wrapped up his rare visit to North Korea, Beijing's strategically important neighbour, announcing that he reached an important consensus with its leader Kim Jong Un on developing relations between the two countries. Soon after his arrival to a colourful red-carpet welcome in Pyongyang on Monday, Xi pledged China's "unwavering" support to Kim, who in recent years deepened ties with Russia much to Beijing's unease. AGENCIES

कार्यालय : जिला परिषद्, चतरा।
(Mail Id- db-chatra@jharkhandmail.gov.in)
(E-mail: districtboardchatra@gmail.com)

(अतिअल्पकालिक ई0 निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना)

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या - 21/2026-27 दिनांक: 09.06.2026

1. कार्य की विस्तृत विवरणी: डी.एम.एफ.टी.

क्र.	प्रमंडल	पंचायत	ग्राम	योजना का नाम	प्राक्कलित राशि	परिमाण विवरण का मूल्य	अग्रघन की राशि	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1	Tandwa	Kichto	Paisratand	Construction of High level RCC Girder bridge over Karamtand nala	4491964 8	10000	898500	18 months

1. वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि - 20/06/2026
2. ई-निविदा प्राप्ति की तिथि एवं समय - 22.06.2026 से 29.06.2026 के अपराह्न 5:00 बजे तक
3. निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय - 01.07.2026 पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे।
4. सरकार द्वारा लिए गए निर्णय के आलोक में सभी कागजात के साथ निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रघन की राशि online Mode द्वारा स्वीकार्य होगी।
5. निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रघन की राशि का ई-मुद्रातन जिस खाता से किया जायेगा, उसी खाते में अग्रघन की राशि वापस होगी। अगर खाता को बंद कर दिया जाता है तो उसकी सारी जवाबदेही संबंधित निविदाकार की होगी।
6. निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम एवं पता - जिला अभियंता जिला परिषद् चतरा।
7. ई-निविदा प्रकोष्ठ का दूरभाष सं० - 9835777636
8. विस्तृत जानकारी के लिये वेबसाइट www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in एवं कार्यालय की सूचना पट्ट पर देखा जा सकता है।

जिला अभियंता,
जिला परिषद्, चतरा।

PR 381965 (District) 26-27 (D)

ATF prices rise about 10% as oil companies roll out fixed pricing

The new rate will be locked in for up to three years for airlines that opt to participate in the government-backed price stabilisation scheme

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices were raised by around 10 per cent on Tuesday as state-owned fuel retailers rolled out a price stabilisation regime, offering domestic airlines a fixed fuel rate for up to three years in a move aimed at shielding carriers and passengers from sharp swings in global oil prices.

Jet fuel for domestic airlines will now cost Rs 115 per litre, up from Rs 104.927, industry sources said.

The new rate will be locked in for up to three years for airlines that opt to participate in the government-backed price stabilisation scheme.

Airlines that do not opt for the scheme will pay market-linked prices, currently around Rs 142 per litre, similar to international carriers.

Those opting into the price stabilisation scheme will continue to receive ATF at Rs 115 per litre, insulated from global benchmark fluctuations. While non-participating carriers will benefit from price declines, they will also face higher costs when international rates rise.

Sources said the scheme is completely voluntary, and air-



Airlines that do not opt for the scheme will pay market-linked prices, currently around Rs 142 per litre, similar to international carriers

lines will have to take a call if they want to participate in it.

Under the voluntary scheme, participating airlines will pay a fixed free-on-board (FOB) benchmark price of Rs 86.32 per litre, plus airport charges, oil company margins and applicable taxes, resulting in an effective selling price of Rs 115 per litre in Delhi, Rs 114.5 in Mumbai and Rs 139 in Chennai.

The new rate compares with

a below-market level of about Rs 105 per litre in Delhi, which had remained unchanged for more than two months after the government allowed only a partial pass-through of higher global fuel costs triggered by the outbreak of the West Asia conflict in late February. The freeze had led to losses for oil marketing companies on aviation turbine fuel (ATF), similar to pressures seen in petrol, diesel and LPG segments.

Highlights

- » Jet fuel for domestic airlines will now cost Rs 115 per litre, up from Rs 104.927, industry sources said
- » Those opting into price stabilisation scheme will continue to receive ATF at Rs 115/litre, insulated from global benchmark fluctuations
- » While non-participating carriers will benefit from price declines, they will also face higher costs when international rates rise

To address these losses, the Union Cabinet approved a Rs 10,000-crore price stabilisation scheme aimed at capping ATF prices and shielding airlines from volatility linked to geopolitical tensions, while also supporting the financial health of state-owned oil companies.

Under the scheme, whenever global benchmark prices rise above the base rate of Rs 86.32, the government will provide an interest-free advance

to oil marketing companies to cover the difference. When prices fall, the differential will be recovered from the companies and returned to the Consolidated Fund of India.

ATF typically accounts for about 40 per cent of airline operating expenses and can rise to as much as 60 per cent during periods of sharp volatility.

Sources said international jet fuel prices had climbed to as high as Rs 142 per litre in May from pre-war rates of Rs 60.50 per litre, raising concerns over airline operating costs and potential fare increases.

The new arrangement, they said, is not a subsidy but a temporary stabilisation framework intended to smooth volatility in fuel prices while ensuring accountability, monitoring and full recovery of funds.

For passengers, the most important benefit of this decision is that it will help to moderate sudden increases in the airfare that often result from sharp spikes in fuel prices.

By reducing the exposure of airlines to extreme fuel price fluctuations, the government aims to minimise the pass-through of such costs to travellers and provide greater fare stability.

GDP growth intact, no additional borrowing needed so far: Sources

On the fiscal deficit front, the sources said the budgeted target of 4.3 per cent of GDP is still intact

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Indian economy is facing headwinds from external sectors with rising fuel and fertiliser import bills due to West Asia crisis, but GDP growth momentum remains intact with domestic consumption holding up, government sources said on Tuesday.

Sources said the FY27 Budget had taken into cognisance the uncertainties in the global economy around tariffs, and the government do not immediately need to account for additional borrowing or bring in supplementary demands for grants in the upcoming monsoon session of Parliament.

On the fiscal deficit front, sources said the budgeted target of 4.3 per cent of GDP is still intact, and the government is actively tapping its non-tax revenue areas like disinvestment and asset monetisation in the current fiscal.

"DIPAM and DPE have a year-long pipeline and also a medium-term outlook of disinvestment and asset monetisation. I would hope the budgeted Rs 80,000 crore under this head exceeds BE and both the departments are working on it," a source said, adding IDBI Bank disinvestment will happen going ahead.

Once the data of the April-June quarter and the impact of El Nino on the monsoon is



'DIPAM and DPE have a year-long pipeline and also a medium-term outlook of disinvestment and asset monetisation'

available, the government will reassess the macroeconomic data in July. Sources said the FY26 March quarter growth momentum is continuing in the first quarter of FY27, and there is no adverse impact on remittances so far.

Besides, GST numbers are good, frequency data are also showing up, and private investment is picking up pace, as shown in the data released by CII, sources said.

Stressing that the reform express will continue, sources said more measures to increase FDI flows into the economy are in the offing, and there is no proposal to curb capital outflow.

Key Points

- » 'I would hope budgeted Rs 80K cr under this head exceeds BE and both the departments are working on it,' a source said, adding IDBI Bank disinvestment will happen going ahead
- » 'The FY26 Q4 growth momentum is continuing in Q1 of FY27 & there is no adverse impact on remittances so far'
- » Budget has estimated a fertiliser subsidy of Rs 1.77 lakh cr for FY27

Sources further said that in view of rising fertiliser prices globally, the fertiliser ministry has sought a 100 per cent increase in subsidy for the current fiscal. The budget has estimated a fertiliser subsidy of Rs 1.77 lakh crore for the current fiscal.

Besides, the government has provided support of Rs 1.23 lakh crore to oil marketing companies to hold pump prices steady for 78 days since the West Asia crisis. After that, the OMCs have started increasing pump prices in a staggered manner, but are still incurring a loss of Rs 650 crore per day for selling fuel at a lower rate than the prevailing global crude price.

FPI inflows into FAR securities rise by ₹8,795 cr after govt tax exemption

MUMBAI: Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have invested Rs 8,794.743 crore in government securities under the Fully Accessible Route (FAR) after the government exempted them from income tax on interest income and capital gains arising from investments in these bonds.

According to data from the Clearing Corporation of India Ltd (CCIL), FPI holdings in FAR securities stood at Rs 3.32 lakh crore on Tuesday, up from Rs 3.23 lakh crore on June 3.

FAR allows non-resident investors to invest in specified Govt of India dated securities without any investment ceilings.

"We can see the optimism from FPIs who nearly invested 75 per cent of the net purchase in G-secs under FAR category recorded during April & May. It also strengthens India's case

FPI holdings in FAR securities stood at Rs 3.32L cr on Tuesday from Rs 3.23L cr on June 3

for inclusion in major global bond indices, such as Bloomberg's sovereign bond index, whose inclusion decision was deferred earlier this year," said Matapasad Pandey, vice-president at Arete Capital.

The government on June 5 promulgated an ordinance amending the Income Tax Act to provide tax exemption on interest income and capital gains arising from the sale, exchange or transfer of government securities held by FPIs. The exemption is applicable retrospectively from April 1, 2025.

The move came as the government looked to attract more foreign capital into the domestic debt market and support the rupee amid external pressures.

Currently, foreign investors are subject to a long-term capital gains tax of 12.5 per cent on listed shares and bonds held for more than 12 months, while interest earned on government bonds attracts a withholding tax of 20 per cent.

The RBI, in its June monetary policy announcement, also expanded the universe of securities available under the FAR by including all new issuances of 15-year, 30-year and 40-year tenor government securities.

The RBI also removed limits related to short-term investment, concentration and individual securities for FPI investments under the general route.

Adani Energy Solutions to acquire smart meter player IntelliSmart for ₹3,050 crore

The proposed acquisition will strengthen AESL's position as India's largest smart metering platform with over 4.7+ crore smart meters

NEW DELHI: Adani Energy Solutions Ltd (AESL) has inked a securities purchase agreement to acquire a 100 per cent equity stake in IntelliSmart Infrastructure for Rs 3,050 crore.

IntelliSmart Infrastructure is a leading smart metering JV between National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF) and Energy Efficiency Services Ltd (EESL), a statement said.

According to the statement, AESL has executed a binding securities purchase and subscription agreement (SPSA) to acquire a 100 per cent equity stake in IntelliSmart Infrastructure.

The proposed acquisition

will strengthen AESL's position as India's largest smart metering platform with over 4.7+ crore smart meters.

The proposed Rs 3,050 crore transaction includes the acquisition of 100 per cent of the equity share capital of IntelliSmart and redemption of the optionally convertible debentures of IntelliSmart held by NIIF.

The completion of the transaction is subject to regulatory and other customary approvals.

IntelliSmart is among leading owners and operators of smart meter assets with a total portfolio of 2.2+ crore meters across Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Bihar and

Assam.

IntelliSmart's presence across high-growth consumer markets provides a strong runway for future expansion.

"Acquisition of IntelliSmart enhances our scale and execution capabilities, enables us to support India's power distribution modernisation through technology-led solutions," said Kandarp Patel, CEO, AESL in the statement.

The acquisition is expected to deliver synergies through economies of scale, optimisation of operations and maintenance costs, and integration with AESL's broader energy and infrastructure platform.

"IntelliSmart is proud to be part of this milestone transaction, which has created value for its stakeholders," said Anil Rawal, MD & CEO, IntelliSmart.

IntelliSmart's evolution into one of the country's leading smart metering platforms reflects NIIF's ability to build and scale infrastructure businesses in emerging sectors of national importance, said Vinod Giri, Managing Partner, NIIF, in the statement. EESL has been committed to enabling energy efficiency and digital transformation across India's power sector," said Akhilesh Dixit, CEO, EESL, in the statement. **MP05T**

Adani Green promoter sells 1.3% stake for ₹3,246 cr to Adani Infra



NEW DELHI: A promoter group entity of Adani Green Energy on Tuesday sold a 1.3 per cent stake to Adani Infra (India) Ltd for Rs 3,246 crore through open market transactions.

According to the block deal data on the National Stock Exchange (NSE) of India Ltd, Ardour Investment Holding Ltd, a promoter entity, offloaded 2,15,00,000 shares representing a 1.3 per cent stake in Adani Green Energy.

The shares were disposed of at an average price of Rs 1,510 apiece, taking the transaction value to Rs 3,246.50 crore.

At the end of the March quarter, Ardour Investment Holding Ltd owned a 6.35 per cent equity stake in the company.

Meanwhile, Adani Infra (India) Ltd acquired the same number of shares, as per the data.

Shares of Adani Green Energy rose nearly 3 per cent to close at Rs 1,532 apiece on the National Stock Exchange (NSE). **PTI**

'Indian online buyers losing up to ₹28,000 cr annually to dark patterns, hidden charges'

NEW DELHI: Indian consumers are losing an estimated Rs 25,000 crore to Rs 28,000 crore annually due to deceptive interface designs, commonly known as dark patterns, across online marketplaces, according to a report.

The 'Dark Patterns in India's Online Marketplaces' report, released by market research firm Datum Intelligence on Tuesday, said 88 per cent of the country's 304 million online buyers lose approximately Rs 78 to Rs 87 per month each to hidden charges, forced add-ons, drip pricing, false urgency rules and subscription traps.

"Existing regulatory interventions have so far had limited



success in curbing deceptive digital practices that continue to impact millions of consumers," the report noted.

The survey found that 63 per cent of online payment users now experience hidden charges or drip pricing—where additional fees are revealed at the checkout stage. This marks an increase from the 52 per cent reported in 2024.

Furthermore, 73 per cent of the platforms assessed deploy forced action mechanisms, compelling users into actions they might not otherwise choose. The study analysed 12 leading platforms across e-commerce, quick commerce and online travel.

The survey was conducted in the first quarter of 2026 among 2,590 consumers across 50 cities. Among e-commerce platforms, Amazon emerged as the most trusted, with 50 per cent of users naming it their preferred choice. In contrast, Flipkart was the only platform where distrust (41 per cent) exceeded trust (37 per cent), a gap the report attributed to higher per-encounter

'financial extraction'.

In the online travel sector, MakeMyTrip was perceived as the safest, while Cleartrip ranked among the most harmful. In the quick commerce segment, BigBasket recorded one of the highest severity scores, the report added.

The study also highlighted an "awareness paradox" among Indian shoppers.

While 81 per cent of respondents said they were aware of dark patterns, 85 per cent still reported being misled by them.

However, 74 per cent of online shoppers indicated a willingness to pay more for platforms that commit to fair and transparent design practices. **PTI**

BAE Systems appoints Tony Walton as India MD

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Global defence, aerospace and security company, BAE Systems, on Tuesday announced the appointment of Tony Walton as Managing Director for India. He will lead BAE Systems' in-country operations, focusing on supporting delivered hardware, developing new opportunities and fostering greater collaboration with the Indian defence sector. He will be based in New Delhi.

Tony Walton brings over three decades of international

Tony Walton brings over three decades of int'l defence industry and military experience

defence industry and military experience. He joined BAE Systems in 2022 and most recently led Guided Weapons and Autonomy campaigns in Australia, according to a company press release here.

Losses, ED probe, regulatory scrutiny key risks in IPO filing: Zepto

In its updated Draft Red Herring Prospectus, firm disclosed that it has incurred losses in every fiscal since inception

NEW DELHI: Quick commerce firm Zepto has identified continued losses, a recent ED summons to its promoters, and heightened regulatory scrutiny over consumer protection practices as key risk factors ahead of its proposed IPO.

In its updated Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) filed on Monday, the Bengaluru-based company said it has reported losses every year since its incorporation in July 2021 and may continue to post losses and negative operating cash flows as it invests in expanding its customer base, technology infrastructure, product



categories, private labels, supply chain operations and dark store network.

The company cautioned that there is no guarantee such investments will translate into higher future revenues. It also warned that revenue growth

CLOSER LOOK

- » The company said its revenue growth may decline due to slowing demand, limited product categories
- » Zepto's net loss widened to Rs 5,905.19 crore in FY26 from Rs 4,699.71 crore in previous financial year
- » For Q4 2026, Zepto narrowed its net loss to Rs 1,538.67 cr, down from Rs 1,831.91 cr in Q4 FY25

could slow due to weakening demand, limited product offerings, intense competition and rising regulatory and compliance costs.

Zepto's net loss widened to Rs 5,905.19 crore in FY26 from Rs 4,699.71 crore a year



The issue will open for retail investors on Wednesday.

The stake sale comprises a base offer size of 2 per cent, and an additional 1 per cent green-shoe option in case of over-subscription. If fully subscribed, the stake sale would fetch about Rs 1,200 crore to the exchequer at

the floor price.

The floor price represents a 9.73 per cent discount over NLC India's closing price of Rs 335.65 a share on the BSE on Monday.

Shares of NLC India closed at Rs 327.85, down 2.32 per cent over previous close on the BSE.

The government currently holds 72.20 per cent in NLC India. So far in the current fiscal year, the government has mopped up Rs 12,166 crore by selling minority stakes in PSUs. This include Rs 5,542 crore from Coal India, Rs 4,357 crore from NHPC and Rs 2,266 crore from Central Bank of India. **PTI**

with the CCPA over alleged use of "dark patterns", including basket sneaking, misleading advertisements and drip pricing. The regulator imposed a Rs 7 lakh penalty, which Zepto has challenged before the National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission. An interim stay has been granted in the case.

Zepto also underscored its dependence on an expanding dark store network, warning that failure to scale it cost-effectively could hurt operations and financial performance. The firm operated 1,139 dark stores as of FY26, up from 1,029 in FY25 and 337 in FY24. **AGENCIES**

DESPITE GLOBAL UNCERTAINTIES

‘India’s fundamentals, strategic ties to support economic growth’

‘India’s growth story remains supported by investments in people, businesses and expanding international partnerships’

AHMEDABAD: India has a strong foundation for economic growth and is expected to maintain robust growth momentum in the coming years despite global uncertainties, said Paul Procee, Operations Manager and Acting Country Director for India at the World Bank.

Speaking on the sidelines of the SAPLING High-Level Policy Dialogue co-hosted by the World Bank Group and the Union Ministry of Food Processing Industries, Procee said India’s growth story remains supported by investments in people, businesses and expanding international partnerships.

“India has a very strong baseline growth and basically has a huge economy. And as long as we focus on what we doing here, which is basically focus on building businesses, India is creating very nice partnerships and trade agreements with bilateral partners. So India is really taking care of itself by investing in its people, investing in its businesses, and with that it will continue having a very strong base growth for the



The country’s strength lies in creating a favourable business environment and supporting pvt sector growth, Paul Procee, Operations Manager and Acting Country Director for India at the World Bank said

coming years,” he said. When asked about India’s attractiveness as an investment destination amid global economic challenges, Procee said the country’s strength lies in creating a favourable business environment and supporting

private sector growth. “I think, again, India is a continent. I cannot specify one sector. It is really about creating a business environment where people can invest, where foreign investments, local investments will go into building the private

Highlights

» ‘India is creating very nice partnerships and trade agreements with bilateral partners’

» ‘India is really taking care of itself by investing in its people, investing in its businesses, and with that it will continue having a very strong base growth for the coming years’

» ‘India’s large consumer base and growing network of trade agreements offer significant opportunities for investors’

sector,” he said. He added that India’s large consumer base and growing network of trade agreements offer significant opportunities for investors. “There’s a lot of, let’s say, potential as well with con-

sumers in India. So India has everything. And as I said before, there’s a lot of free trade agreements that are coming up, bilateral agreements where India can profit a lot and where India will basically continue to grow strongly,” Procee said.

Highlighting opportunities in the food processing sector, the World Bank official described it as one of India’s most promising areas for future growth. “Actually, it is one of the big manufacturing sectors. It already is one of the main exporting sectors within India,” he said.

Procee said the World Bank and the government would focus on strengthening value chains and improving market linkages for farmers.

“I see a humongous potential for growth in this sector. Because it is, at the end of the day, 60 per cent of the people still live in rural areas,” he said.

He also noted that developing food processing can create jobs and economic opportunities in rural India. AGENCIES

Fitch cuts India’s GDP growth forecast for current fiscal to 6.4%

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Fitch Ratings on Tuesday lowered its GDP growth projections for the current fiscal to 6.4 per cent from the earlier estimate of 6.7 per cent, saying that the US-Iran war will slow down the economy in the September and December quarters.

Fitch said it expects a slowdown in economic growth in FY27 from the 7.4 per cent clocked in FY26 as rising prices erode real incomes and dampen consumer spending, amid a resilient capital expenditure.

“We expect GDP growth to ease to 6.4 per cent in FY27, a downward revision of 0.3pp from March. Domestic demand will be the main driver of growth, but lower imports in real terms imply positive contributions to growth from net external demand,” Fitch Ratings said in its June Global Economic Outlook.

Last week, the RBI had cut its growth forecast for the current fiscal to 6.6 per cent and upped its inflation projection to 5.1 per cent.

The rating agency said the slowdown in the economy will be most apparent in the second and third quarter of FY27, as rising prices due to the US-Iran war erode real incomes and dampen consumer spending. Fuel prices have both risen by 4-5 per cent in recent weeks.

For FY28, Fitch expects GDP growth to pick up as the

‘Domestic demand will be the main driver of growth, but lower imports in real terms imply positive contributions to growth from net external demand’

energy shock unwinds, with stronger consumer spending and investment translating to a growth rate of 6.7 per cent for the full financial year, and ease towards trend growth of 6.4 per cent in FY29.

Fitch has also lowered its 2026 forecast for global growth by 0.2pp to 2.4 per cent as world growth prospects have been hurt by the oil crisis prompted by the US-Iran war.

“The oil price shock is hitting world growth prospects and increasing downside risks. But we are also amid a very pronounced boom in global spending on IT and that is cushioning the impact on activity in the near term, particularly in Asia,” said Fitch. Chief Economist, Brian Coulton said.

The closure of the Strait of Hormuz has now lasted 14 weeks and we assume it will not start to reopen until July.

Fitch has revised its 2026 average price assumption for Brent crude oil to \$87 per barrel (bbl), up from the \$70/bbl

estimated in March. The oil shock is a strong headwind to world growth, but its base case is far less severe than the pernicious oil shocks of the 1970s. Real oil prices reached USD170/bbl in 1979 (measured in current prices) and OPEC played a very different role then. Oil consumption as a share of world GDP has halved since 1980.

Fitch said India’s consumer price inflation has not yet risen significantly, but price pressures are mounting; wholesale prices rose by 8.3 per cent y/y in April and CPI inflation to 3.5 per cent.

“We expect inflation to rise steadily over the months ahead, reaching 5.3 per cent by the end of the (calendar) year. This reflects a combination of base effects and higher energy prices. Forecasts for below-average monsoon rains and the current heatwave in parts of India raise the risk of even stronger price rises,” Fitch said.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) kept its policy rate at 5.25 per cent in April. But Fitch expects RBI to change course and increase rates once this year to 5.5 per cent to address the rising price pressures from the adverse supply shock.

“We do not expect a further, significant depreciation in the Indian rupee over the rest of the year,” Fitch said. The global rating agency expects the exchange rate to average 97.50 to a dollar in current fiscal.

Rupee jumps 20 paise to 95.41/dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee appreciated 20 paise to close at 95.41 against the US dollar on Tuesday, as Brent crude oil prices and the US dollar index retreated from their elevated levels after a pause in US-Iran hostilities.

Forex traders said besides the de-escalation of tensions in the West Asia war, likely intervention by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), positive domestic markets and easing US treasury yields supported the rupee.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.47, then touched an intraday high of 95.23 and a low of 95.67 against the US dollar. The rupee finally ended the session at 95.41, registering a rise of 20 paise from its previous close.

“We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias due to uncertainty in the West Asia war. Any fresh escalations in the West Asia war may again lead to a spike in crude oil prices and pressurise the rupee.

“However, if the de-escalation remains, we may see some recovery in the rupee. Traders may take cues from ADP weekly employment, trade balance and existing home sales data from the US. USDINR spot price is expected to trade in a range of 95.10 to 95.80,” said Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst at Mirae Asset ShareKhan.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.80, down 0.24 per cent. PTI

India’s exports rising steadily due to policy push & reforms: Official

JAIPUR: India’s exports have witnessed consistent growth in recent years, driven by supportive government policies, improved digital infrastructure, better logistics and trade reforms, a senior Commerce Ministry official said on Tuesday.

Speaking at a regional media interaction organised by the Apparel Export Promotion Council (AEPCC) and the Department of Commerce here, Senior Economic Adviser Agrim Kaushal highlighted the government’s commitment to making India a global leader in the textiles and apparel sector.

He referred to the Prime Minister’s “5F vision” — “Farm to Fibre, Fibre to Factory, Factory to Fashion, and Fashion to Foreign” — as a key framework guiding the sector’s growth.

During the session themed

“Strengthening India’s Position in Global Apparel Trade: Opportunities, Challenges and the Way Forward,” Kaushal outlined major initiatives such as the PLI scheme, PM MITRA parks, Mega Textile Parks, the National Technical Textiles Mission and various export promotion measures.

“These efforts have strengthened India’s textile value chain and enhanced the country’s competitiveness in global markets,” he said.

Kaushal also underlined opportunities arising from India’s expanding network of FTAs and the recently launched Export Promotion Mission.

Highlighting Rajasthan’s role, he said Jaipur has emerged as the largest apparel export hub in the state, contributing around 86 per cent to Rajasthan’s total ready-made garment exports.

“Exporters here have successfully combined traditional craftsmanship with modern technology to access markets in the US, Europe, the Middle East, and the Asia-Pacific region,” he added.

Rajasthan Garment Exporters’ Association (GEAR) President Rakshit Poddar said exporters in Jaipur have adapted to evolving global market demands while preserving their unique design and handicraft identity.

AEPCC Executive Committee member Aseem Kumar stressed the need for increased investment in skill development, technological upgrade, sustainable production, and infrastructure.

Officials said recent and proposed trade agreements are expected to further open new markets for Indian apparel exporters. PTI

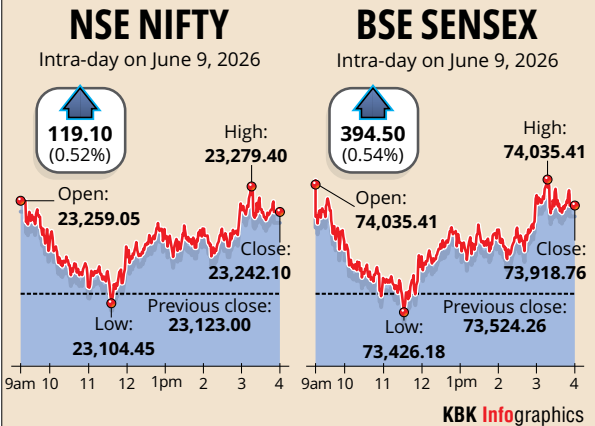
MUMBAI: Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty found firmer ground on Tuesday after sliding for the past two sessions, propelled by intense buying in banking and financial stocks amid a recovery in global markets and easing crude prices.

Signs of easing tensions in West Asia added to markets’ optimism, but unrelenting foreign fund outflows capped the gains, traders said.

In a volatile trade, the 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 394.50 points, or 0.54 per cent, to settle at 73,918.76. During the day, it jumped 511.15 points, or 0.69 per cent, to 74,035.41.

A total of 2,782 stocks advanced, while 1,423 declined and 193 remained unchanged on the BSE.

The 50-share NSE Nifty ended 119.10 points, or 0.52



per cent, higher at 23,242.10. Intra-day, the benchmark index climbed 156.4 points, or 0.67 per cent, to 23,279.40.

Among the Sensex firms, InterGlobe Aviation, State Bank of India, ICICI Bank, Axis Bank, Bajaj Finance and

Asian Paints were the major winners.

On the other hand, Titan, NTPC, Power Grid and Tech Mahindra were among the laggards.

The BSE MidCap Select index jumped 1.50 per cent,

and the SmallCap Select index went up by 1.33 per cent.

Sectorally, PSU Bank surged 3.83 per cent, Mid-Small Private Banks Quality Tilt jumped 3.06 per cent, Bankex (2.18 per cent), Services (2 per cent), Realty (1.76 per cent), Financial Services (1.60 per cent) and Top 10 Banks (1.59 per cent).

In contrast, IT, Utilities and Focused IT were the laggards. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, declined 1.66 per cent to USD 92.69 per barrel.

Meanwhile, FIIs offloaded equities worth Rs 5,555.67 crore on Monday, according to exchange data.

On Monday, the Sensex tumbled 719.08 points, or 0.97 per cent, to close at 73,524.26. The Nifty settled 243.70 points, or 1.04 per cent, lower at 23,123. PTI

HDFC Bank hikes lending rates by up to 10 bps

NEW DELHI: Private sector lender HDFC Bank has increased the Marginal Cost of funds-based Lending Rate (MCLR) by up to 10 basis points across tenors effective June 8, 2026.

The maximum hike of 10 basis points was for loans having a maturity of two years to 8.55 per cent from the earlier 8.45 per cent.

The benchmark one-year MCLR has been revised up by 5 basis points to 8.40 per cent, as per the data available on the HDFC Bank website. The one-year rate is used to fix most consumer loans, such as auto, personal and home loans.

The overnight, three-month, six-month and three-



year tenor MCLR have been raised by 5 basis points to 8.10 per cent, 8.20 per cent, 8.35 per cent and 8.65 per cent, respectively.

The MCLR hike decision comes days after the Reserve Bank on Friday expectedly kept interest rates unchanged for the second time in a row as it weighed the impact of rising energy prices and supply disruptions caused by the West Asia crisis. PTI

RBI exempts fresh FCNR(B) deposits from CRR, SLR norms till Sept 30

MUMBAI: The RBI has exempted fresh Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) [FCNR(B)] deposits mobilised by banks from Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) and Statutory Liquidity Ratio (SLR) requirements, in a move aimed at facilitating foreign currency inflows under the announced US Dollar-Rupee swap facility.

In four separate notifications issued on Monday for commercial banks, small finance banks, rural co-operative banks and regional rural banks, the central bank said the exemption would apply to fresh FCNR(B) deposits with a minimum tenor of three years and a maximum tenor of five years raised up to September 30, 2026.

The RBI said the move fol-



lows the Governor’s announcement on June 5. In all four notifications, the central bank noted that it had been decided “to introduce a US Dollar-Rupee swap facility for fresh Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) [FCNR (B)] dollar funds, mobilised for a minimum tenor of three years and maximum tenor of five years.”

Referring to the existing CRR and SLR directions, the RBI said, “It has been decided that fresh FCNR (B) deposits of minimum tenor of three

years and maximum tenor of five years mobilized (including deposits that are renewed upon maturity) by the banks from the date of this Amendment Directions till September 30, 2026 will be exempted from maintenance of CRR and SLR.”

The exemption covers commercial banks, small finance banks, rural co-operative banks and regional rural banks through corresponding amendments to their respective CRR and SLR directions for 2025. The provisions shall come into force with immediate effect.

According to the RBI, “The exemption on reserves maintenance is available for the original deposit amounts till such time the deposits are held in the bank books.” AGENCIES

Govt notifies rules to set up coal exchanges to modernise coal trade

Public sector players can also use the platform to increase market participation

NEW DELHI: The government on Tuesday said it has published rules for setting up coal exchanges, a move aimed at bringing transparency and efficiency to the country’s coal trading ecosystem and modernising the supply chain.

Coal exchanges are expected to enable transparent, market-driven price discovery, boost efficiency and give coal producers — including commercial and captive miners — easier access to a wider pool of buyers.

Public sector players can also use the platform to increase market participation.

“The recently enacted Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2025 introduced the concept of a mineral exchange and empowered the central government to promote transparent and efficient trading of minerals, including coal and its processed forms. In pursuance of the above, the Coal Exchange Rules, 2026 have been published

by the Ministry of Coal in the Official Gazette on June 4,” the coal ministry said.

The ministry has already designated the Coal Controller Organisation (CCO) in December 2025 as the authority responsible for registering and regulating coal exchanges. Eligible entities will be authorised by CCO to establish & operate coal exchanges, frame market rules and bye-laws, and facilitate coal trading. Registrations will be granted for 25 years. PTI

GeM leverages AI to boost procurement efficiency

NEW DELHI: The government’s e-marketplace platform GeM is leveraging artificial intelligence-based tools, advanced analytics and digital monitoring systems to enhance efficiency, transparency and accountability in public procurement, a senior government official said on Tuesday.

GeM Chief Executive Officer (CEO) Mihir Kumar also said that the platform has enabled savings of about 8 per cent for the exchequer by making public procurement more efficient and transparent.

“The platform is leveraging artificial intelligence-based tools, advanced analytics, digital

monitoring systems and transparent auction mechanisms to improve efficiency, accountability and user experience across procurement processes,” he told reporters here. He added that the platform is using AI-ML (artificial intelligence-machine learning) tools and it is helping in promoting more transparency at the price front.

The platform facilitated transactions worth Rs 5.03 lakh crore in 2025-26, down 7.4 per cent from the previous fiscal.

The portal was launched on August 9, 2016, for online purchases of goods and services by all the central government ministries and departments. PTI

Electric PV retail sales rise 81.20% to 26,682 units in May, says FADA

NEW DELHI: Electric passenger vehicle retail sales in India grew by 81.20 per cent to 26,682 units in May against 14,725 units in May 2025, Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations said on Tuesday.

Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd continued to lead the pack with 10,340 units sold last month, up 103.42 per cent from 5,083 units in May 2025, FADA said in a statement. Homegrown rival Mahindra & Mahindra followed in the second spot with 6,210 units in May 2026, as against 2,891 units in the year-ago month, up 114.8 per cent, it added. JSW MG Motor



India was in the third position at 4,984 units last month, as against 4,599 units, FADA said.

In the electric two-wheeler segment, total sales grew by 62.76 per cent to 1,70,733 units last month as compared to 1,04,896 units in May 2025, FADA said.

TVS Motor Company led the segment with retail sales

of 42,459 units in May 2026 as compared to 25,804 units in the same month last year, a growth of 64.54 per cent, it added.

Bajaj Auto was in the second spot with 39,202 units as against 22,642 units, followed by Ather Energy with 68,240 units as compared to 14,101 units in May 2025, as per the FADA data.

Total electric three-wheeler retail sales last month stood at 71,867 units as against 68,185 units in May 2025, while overall electric commercial vehicle sales were at 2,400 units as compared to 1,094 units in May 2025, FADA said. PTI



‘What matters is the character, not the medium’

Jisshu Sengupta is excited to share screen with Karisma Kapoor in the web series ‘Brown’

URJA SAHA

Six months into 2026, Jisshu Sengupta has already had three major releases, including ‘Mardaani 3’, ‘Bhoot Bangla’ and the ‘ZEE5’ web series ‘Brown’. Up next is one of his most ambitious Bengali projects, ‘Abhhiiman’, which will see the actor take on an intense role both on and off screen. While ‘Brown’, starring Karisma Kapoor, was shot in Kolkata in 2022, the story of ‘Abhhiimaan’ has been with Jisshu for over 16 years. “This story has been in my mind since 2010 or 2011,” the actor revealed during a phone conversation on a sultry afternoon. “Though he is ‘very, very excited’ about the neo-noir crime drama ‘Brown’, Jisshu admitted that ‘Abhhiiman’ occupies a special place in his heart. “I’m excited as well as very tense because in ‘Abhhiiman’, I am both an actor and a producer,” he said. In ‘Brown’ on ‘Zee5’, ‘Delhi Belly’ director Abhinay Deo follows the story of Rita Brown (Karisma Kapoor), an Anglo-Indian detective with the Kolkata Police Force who investigates a complex case while battling her own personal demons. Jisshu



“Karisma Kapoor has done a fabulous job, and taking up this kind of role at this stage of her career is brilliant. People will get to see a new Karisma Kapoor”

essays the role of psychiatrist Dr Sandeep Chakraborty. Despite the series being set and shot in Kolkata, Jisshu said the city itself had little influence on his decision to join the project. “Not at all. It was the story, my character and of course, Abhinay Deo,” he said. ‘Brown’ is based on Abheek Barua’s novel ‘City of Death’ and also stars Surya Sharma, Soni Razdan, Helen and Shaan. Jisshu recalled

that he didn’t take long to sign on for the project. “I loved the character, so I said yes,” he said. The actor is equally effusive in his praise for Karisma Kapoor, describing her as ‘humble, grounded and really sweet’. He admitted that working with her brought back memories of the many Govinda-Karisma blockbusters he watched in the 1990s. “Karisma Kapoor has done a fabulous job and tak-

ing up this kind of role at this stage of her career is brilliant. People will get to see a new Karisma Kapoor,” he added. If ‘Brown’ marks one exciting chapter in Jisshu’s career, ‘Abhhiiman’ represents a long-cherished dream. The film marks the first joint production venture between Jisshu and actor Saurav Das and is rooted in an idea that has stayed with him for more than a decade. “I had discussed it with Rituparno Ghosh while working on ‘Abohomaan’ in 2009. He told me it was a good story and encouraged me to save it for the day I directed a film,” recalled Jisshu. While that directorial debut never materialised, the idea eventually evolved into a production venture. ‘Abhhiiman’ is an emotionally layered drama about memory, legacy and the cost of love, set against the haunting worlds of music and cinema. The film also stars Prosenjit Chatterjee and Subhashree Ganguly. The stakes are understandably high. The project reunites Jisshu with Bengali cinema veteran Prosenjit Chatterjee, with whom he has shared the screen numerous times over the years. “Bumba da is like my big brother. Working with him again feels like a homecoming,” he said affectionately. At a time when success on both theatrical and OTT platforms remains increasingly unpredictable, Jisshu insists there is no fixed formula behind his choice of projects. Having worked across theatre, TV, films and streaming platforms, he believes the medium is secondary to the role itself. “It doesn’t matter to me whether a project is for OTT or cinema. What matters is my character within the story and whether the project is worth doing,” he said.

5 SHOWS THAT REDEFINED QUEER ROMANCE ON SCREEN

Stories like ‘Four More Shots Please!’, ‘The Royals’ and ‘Made in Heaven’ do more than represent identity

OUR CORRESPONDENT

For decades, queer characters in Indian entertainment were often relegated to the sidelines - reduced to stereotypes, comic relief or narratives defined solely by struggle. But over the last few years, streaming has brought about a meaningful shift. With more room for nuance and a growing appetite for authentic storytelling, platforms, creators and production houses have opened up space for queer stories that are warmer, messier, more intimate and far more human.

These stories do more than represent identity. They allow queer characters to fall in love, make mistakes, build lives, wrestle with belonging and exist beyond the burden of explanation.

This Pride Month, here are five titles that have helped redefine queer romance on screen, proving that love, in all its forms, deserves to be seen, celebrated and understood.

Four More Shots Please!



One of the earliest mainstream Indian streaming shows to spotlight a queer lead, ‘Four More Shots Please!’ introduced audiences to Umang Singh (Bani J), a bisexual gym trainer whose identity extended far beyond her sexuality. Through her relationships, ambitions, vulnerabilities and self-discovery, the show portrayed queer representation with nuance, agency

and emotional depth, helping normalise LGBTQIA+ stories in Indian OTT storytelling.



Made in Heaven

Few Indian shows have explored queer identity as thoughtfully as ‘Made in Heaven’. Through Karan Mehra (Arjun Mathur), the series examines the realities of navigating sexuality in contemporary India, capturing themes of silence, shame, longing and self-acceptance. Across both seasons, Karan’s relationships, including his connection with Nawab (Vikrant Massey), are portrayed with emotional honesty, presenting queer love and companionship in a way that feels authentic, nuanced and deeply human.

The Royals



Beneath its glamorous, royal backdrop, ‘The Royals’ offers a refreshing queer storyline through Princess Divyaranjini ‘Jinnie’ Singh (Kavya Trehan) and Niki (Lisa Mishra), the confident head of design on Sophia’s team. As their connection deepens, Jinnie embarks on a journey of self-discovery, identity and acceptance, bringing queer romance into a space

rarely explored in mainstream Indian storytelling, where royalty meets coming-of-age and modern relationships.

Modern Love Mumbai



Inspired by real-life stories of love in all its forms, ‘Modern Love Mumbai’ expands the definition of romance beyond traditional relationships. Among the anthology’s standout stories, Hansal Mehra’s ‘Baa’ is a deeply moving exploration of queer identity and emotional belonging. It follows Manzu (Pratik Gandhi), a closeted gay man navigating the complexities of coming out to his conservative family, especially his ailing grandmother, while holding on to his relationship with his partner Rajveer (Ranveer Brar). Rather than centring only on trauma, the story foregrounds love, family and acceptance, making it far more than a conventional coming-out narrative.



Class

A bold reimaging of adolescence, privilege and social divides, ‘Class’ resonated strongly with younger audiences for its unapologetic portrayal of identity and desire. The series integrates queer relationships seamlessly into its storytelling, reflecting a generation that views love through a more inclusive lens. Among its most memorable arcs is the relationship between Dhruv Sanghvi (Chayan Chopra) and Faruq Manzoor (Chintan Rach), which became one of the show’s most talked-about storylines.

The most powerful stories are often the ones that expand our understanding of the world and of each other. The growing presence of queer narratives in Indian entertainment is not just a reflection of evolving audience preferences; it signals a storytelling ecosystem that is becoming more courageous, empathetic and representative. From groundbreaking series like ‘Four More Shots Please!’ and ‘Made in Heaven’ to thoughtful anthologies like ‘Modern Love Mumbai’ and newer mainstream titles embracing inclusivity, these stories have helped move queer love from the margins to the centre of the cultural conversation.

Sport

A cup of surprises and hopes

Crowns, comebacks and contenders: Women’s T20 WC packs a punch

BENGALURU: Will India complete a historic double? Can Australia regain lost ground? Will this be eternal bridesmaid South Africa’s turn to stand under the spotlight? Or will an underdog script a thrilling triumph? The 10th edition of the ICC Women’s T20 World Cup, starting on June 12 in England, offers several exciting possibilities and we take a look at the contenders and challengers.

India After winning the ODI World Cup last year, India will be eager to bag the T20 version to complete a grand double, something only Australia have managed to achieve. The Harmanpreet Kaur-led side has the wherewithal to do it, evidenced by their series wins at home against Sri Lanka and Australia in the last six months. But India faltered against South Africa (4-1) and England (2-1) away, and they will also miss the wily pace all-rounder Amanjot Kaur, who could have been a key operator in English



India won by 28 runs against West Indies in a warm up match

conditions. The Women in Blue will hope that the batters will find their groove from the outset, and the pace trio of Renuka Singh, Arundhati Reddy and Kranti Goud can come up with incisive spells. Some of the leading players such as Smriti Mandhana, Jemimah Rodrigues, Harmanpreet, Deepti Sharma, and Richa Ghosh have played in the Hundred and Kia Super League, and that experience will come handy.

Australia The six-time winners have a new skipper in Sophie Molineux after Alyssa Healy called it a day. But Australia’s real strength is in their familiar, proven core -- Elysse Perry, Tahlia McGrath, Ashleigh Gardner, Megan Schutt, Alana King, and Beth Mooney.

The addition of prolific opener Georgia Voll and left-arm pacer Lucy Hamilton has further strengthened their squad.

New Zealand The title holders are coming with a squad that has experience and youth in the right mix, and could be a tough bunch to beat. Their hopes will revolve mainly around Sophie Devine, Suzie Bates and Lea Tahuhu and the Kiwis want to win the title for them as the troika will move away after this showpiece. However, all-rounder Amelia Kerr will be a key factor in New Zealand’s run as she has been in wonderful touch of late with the bat. She was the player of the final and tournament in 2024.

England The home side will be eagerly monitoring the fitness of regular skipper Nat Sciver-Brunt, who missed the recent series against India. She is expected to be fit for the tournament. But England, led by Charlie Dean, proved in that series that they can win without Sciver-Brunt, coming back from a 0-1 deficit to register a 2-1 victory.

They also have very handy players in Alice Capsey, Sophie Ecclestone, Linsey Smith, Freya Kemp and veterans Heather Knight and Danni Wyatt-Hodge. **South Africa** In their effort to land a maiden title, South Africa have brought in experienced pacer Shabnim Ismail, but their real strength lies in flexible players like Nadine de Klerk, Sune Luus, Chloe Tryon, Dane van Niekerk, who can land a heavy punch at any stage of the game. Led by a composed Laura Wolvaardt, South Africa also have a capable bowling unit in Marizanne Kapp, Ayabonga Khaka and Annerie Dercksen. They are in the same group as India and Australia, and that makes it mandatory for them to always be on their guard to progress to the semifinals. **The Darkhorse: Sri Lanka** The Islanders are the form side coming into this World Cup, winning five away matches against Bangladesh and the West Indies. AGENCIES

NEW DELHI: India are not lacking in self-belief after their historic women’s ODI World Cup triumph last year and they are the ‘favourites’ to win the upcoming T20 World Cup in England, says star batter Jemimah Rodrigues.

The women’s T20 World Cup begins on June 12, and India play their first match on Sunday against Pakistan in Birmingham. New Zealand are the defending champions while South Africa ended as runners-up in the last edition in 2024. India are placed in the six-team Group A along with Australia, South Africa, Pakistan, Bangladesh and the Netherlands. Two teams from the group will qualify for the semifinals.

“Everyone was a part of it (the ODI World Cup win); they know what pressure feels like and, at the same time, everyone knows that we’ve crossed the line once and can do it again. That belief rubs off,” Jemimah said on JioStar’s ‘Champions Huddle’. “But when you win



Jemimah Rodrigues is all set to hit the ground running

one, you don’t want to stop there. You want to make it two, three, however many you can. Our fans make us feel at home wherever we go. So, yes, we are the favourites, no doubt about that.” The 25-year-old Jemimah was one of the stars of India’s maiden ODI World Cup triumph in 2025 at home. “Many times, we visualise success so much, but now we’ve actually lived it. That helps us believe even more that we can do it again. It’s great to have so many members from the 2025 World Cup squad in this team, along with a few more youngsters coming in. I think the

energy will rub off on them. Everyone is going to share their experiences,” she said. India captain Harmanpreet Kaur said the ODI World Cup win has boosted the team’s confidence of bagging more global events. “Yeah, 100 per cent. I think everybody will agree with me that life has completely changed after winning our first ODI World Cup. Hopefully, we’ll continue this run of winning trophies. This is what I want as a captain, and I think it’s what everyone in our team has been dreaming of. Hopefully, we’ll continue moving in this direction.” AGENCIES

IRELAND AND ENGLAND TOURS

Siraj rested as Team India turn to Prasidh

MUMBAI: Mohammed Siraj has been rested as part of workload management, with Prasidh Krishna named as his replacement for Ireland and England tours, the BCCI said on Tuesday. The Indian Cricket Board described the move as a “precautionary measure” to ensure quick recovery ahead of the long international season. Siraj was named in the squad for the Ireland and England series consisting two and five T20Is respectively but was not picked for the Asian Games in Japan. “Fast bowler Mohammed Siraj has been withdrawn from



Mohammed Siraj had a fair

India’s squads for the upcoming T20I series against Ireland and England,” the BCCI said

in a statement. “Following discussions between the BCCI Medical Team and the Team

Management, Siraj has been advised a period of rest as part of his workload management programme. “The decision has been taken as a precautionary measure to ensure adequate recovery ahead of a long international season. The Men’s Selection Committee has named Prasidh Krishna as Siraj’s replacement for both T20I series,” the BCCI added. Siraj was a late addition to the Indian squad in their last T20I assignment — the T20 World Cup, while he played in each of the 17 matches for Gujarat Titans in the IPL 2026, taking 19 wickets. AGENCIES

Old guard, same spark: Over-40s set to light up WC

LONDON: In a sport where youth is a highly prized commodity, the World Cup starting this week offers evidence you cannot keep a good man down. A record eight players aged 40 or older have been selected to play at the tournament in Canada, Mexico and the United States - one more than at all the past 22 tournaments combined. The previous entrants in this rarefied category include six goalkeepers and Cameroonian striker Roger Milla, who remains the oldest man to score at the finals after netting at 42 in the 1994 tournament. Milla’s achievement won’t be bettered this time around, but the likes of Cristiano Ronaldo, Luka Modric and Edin



At 41, Cristiano Ronaldo is the oldest outfield player

Dzeko will be looking to join him in the over-40 World Cup goalscorers’ club. The oldest player of all at the 2026 finals will be 43-year-old Scotland goalkeeper Craig Gordon, who if he plays will slot into second spot in the all-time list of oldest World Cup competitors behind Egypt’s

A record eight players aged 40 or older have been selected to play

Essam El Hadary, who was 45 when he kept goal for Egypt against Saudi Arabia in Volgograd in 2018. Gordon, however, is expected to back up first-choice Angus Gunn. Ronaldo is the oldest outfield player at 41 and participating in a record sixth World Cup, a distinction he shares

with 40-year-old Mexico goalkeeper Guillermo Ochoa, and Lionel Messi, who turns 39 later this month. Portugal coach Roberto Martinez said he would be relying on Ronaldo’s vast experience above all else. “None have lived what he has in the number of decisive games he’s played over his career,” Martinez said. This tournament’s other over-40s players include goalkeepers Vozinha from Cape Verde and 2014 World Cup winner Manuel Neuer, who is hoping to be ready to play for Germany against Curaçao after struggling with a calf injury. Uruguay goalkeeper Fernando Muslera celebrates his 40th birthday next Tuesday. AGENCIES